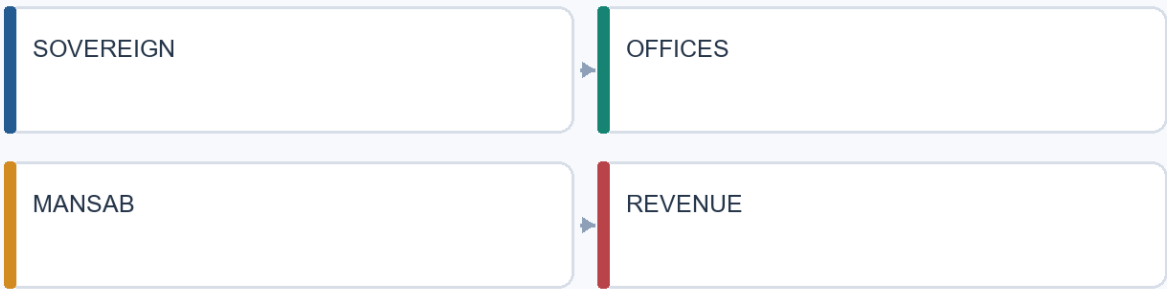


COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Akbar's state: rank, record, revenue



The package is a system map: appointment, rank, verification and assessment work together.

VISUAL 01

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

State & Government under Akbar (Mansabdari, Dahsala) — Complete Topic Package

Subject: Medieval Indian History | **GS Paper:** GS-I + Prelims | **Level:** Foundation to advanced

Package date: 18 August 2026 | **Learning arc:** institutions -> provincial reach -> mansab -> revenue -> sources -> practice

Source and method note: Primary teaching foundation: basic/16_State-and-Government-under-Akbar.md and advanced/16_State-and-Government-under-Akbar.md; chronology: 00_Master-Chronology.md; answer-quality and historiographical guardrails: ANSWER-WORTHINESS-AUDIT.md; continuity links: Topics 07, 14, 15, 17, 21 and 25. Book corroboration used: local OCR text of Satish Chandra, *Medieval India: From Sultanat to the Mughals, Part II*. No current-affairs analogy is forced. FACT marks direct repository/book grounding; ANALYSIS marks a bounded inference.

Roadmap

1. Evolution and kingship
2. Central and provincial administration
3. Mansabdari and verification
4. Dahsala and alternative revenue methods
5. Sources, comparisons and limits
6. PYQ, MCQs and Mains answers
7. Consolidated register notes.

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST Book context: queried from repository Topic 16 files and local Satish Chandra Part II OCR. **CA search:** deliberately not forced; no live claim is needed for this static historical module. **CA found:** none used; modern land-record analogies are bounded functionally and never equated with Mughal title.

PART I — Orientation: a state made through stages, not from zero

Learning objective. Explain why Akbar's government is best read as a ruler-centred, evolving system of rank, record and revenue rather than as an invention-from-zero or a modern bureaucracy. The package follows the repository's basic and advanced Topic 16 files, Satish Chandra Part II OCR evidence, and the cross-links to Topics 07, 14, 15, 17, 21 and 25. It deliberately does not import the later jagirdari crisis as if it were already complete in Akbar's lifetime.

Core thesis. Akbar inherited administrative languages and techniques from the Delhi Sultanate and the Sur interregnum, then reorganised, specialised, replicated and systematised them for an expanding empire. A mansab linked status, remuneration and service. A revenue system converted knowledge of fields, yields and prices into a fiscal claim. Provincial duplication and centrally appointed officers made the court more informed. None of those arrangements dissolved hierarchy, local negotiation, coercion or dependence on the emperor's supervision.

The chronology matters. In 1556 Bairam Khan's powerful *wakil* showed the political danger of a regent who could overshadow a young sovereign. The diwan's fiscal importance strengthened from the 1560s; a numerical mansab hierarchy is generally associated with 1567; Akbar's Mughal-frame *dagh* measure dates to his eighteenth regnal year, 1573-74; revenue experiments culminated in the 1580 adoption of dahsala and division into twelve subas; and the explicit *zat-sawar* distinction arrived only in 1595-96. This sequence forbids the tempting but wrong answer that every component appeared in a finished form at accession.

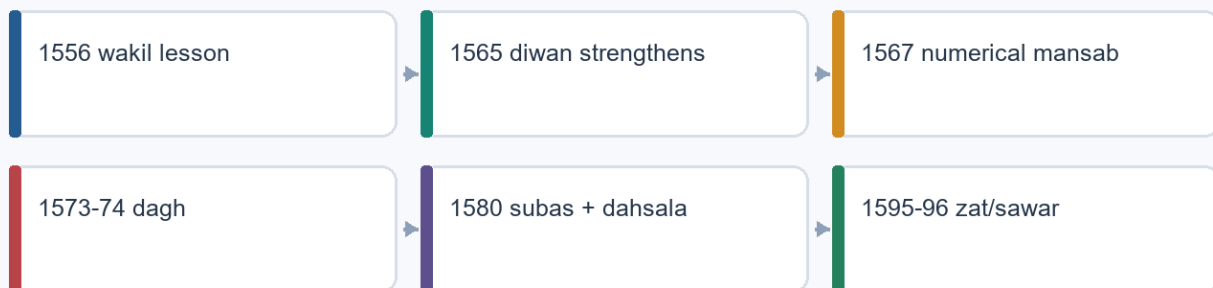
FACT: A chronological explanation earns more than a static list: it can show response to regency, expansion, fiscal experimentation and the need to verify noble service.

Claim	Evidence anchor	Qualification
Akbar built on precedents	Sultanate iqta practice; Sur measurement and controls	Precedent is not proof of institutional sameness

Claim	Evidence anchor	Qualification
He systematised offices	Separate diwan, mir bakhshi and provincial counterparts	Separation remained accountable to the ruler
He extended information	records, musters, revenue returns and news	Records register norms as well as practice

Bounded modern analogy. A cadastral survey, payroll audit or personnel grade can clarify one function—measurement, verification or ranking. It must stop there. Mughal revenue assessment did not create modern registered property title; mansabs were not a meritocratic civil service; subas were not federal provinces; and the court lacked democratic accountability.

Administration evolved across the reign

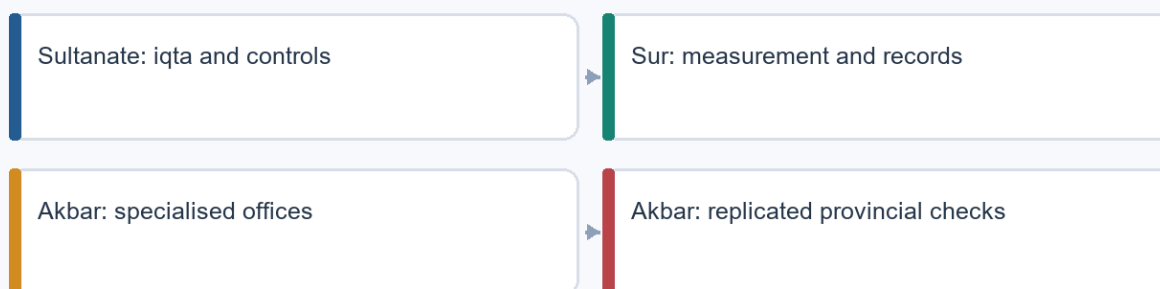


Dates mark stages of adjustment, not a single blueprint imposed in 1556.

VISUAL 02

Dates mark stages of adjustment, not a single blueprint imposed in 1556.

Inheritance, adaptation and systematisation



Continuity does not mean identity: inherited devices were reorganised for a larger imperial framework.

VISUAL 03

Continuity does not mean identity: inherited devices were reorganised for a larger imperial framework.

Ruler-centred monarchy



The emperor remained the nodal authority; office differentiation was a check within personal monarchy.

VISUAL 04

The emperor remained the nodal authority; office differentiation was a check within personal monarchy.

PART II — Kingship and central government

Akbar was the sovereign source of appointment, justice, revenue, military command and patronage. Courtly routines—darbar, access, petitions and, where securely grounded, jharoka darshan—could make authority visible. Their political value was personal communication and display, not a written constitution. The fuller discussion of religious ideology, *sulh-i-kul* and the Ibadat Khana belongs to Topic 17; here the relevant point is that imperial authority authorised offices and resolved conflicts among them.

The *wakil* illustrates this ruler-centred correction. Bairam Khan acted as a powerful regent in Akbar's early reign. Later, the office kept ceremonial prestige but was prevented from becoming a permanent all-powerful wazir. This was not a separation-of-powers doctrine. It was a monarch's lesson that one officer should not monopolise access, decision and patronage.

The diwan or diwan-i-ala headed financial administration: income and expenditure, accounts, scrutiny of khalisa, jagir and inam flows, and supervision of revenue paperwork. It is misleading to write "Todar Mal invented revenue administration." Muzaffar Khan Turbati, Todar Mal and Shah Mansur represent a team of fiscal expertise; their changing roles also reveal that policy was tested and revised. The diwan was not a finance minister in a cabinet answerable to a legislature. It was a specialist office whose competence increased the emperor's capacity to audit.

The mir bakhshi connected the emperor to the service elite. He handled presentation and recommendations of mansabdars, muster-related records and military payment machinery; in the source tradition he is also associated with intelligence/news and high appointments. The safe formulation is functional: he was a nodal officer for rank, military personnel and records. Calling him a modern defence minister falsely implies a separate department with autonomous command.

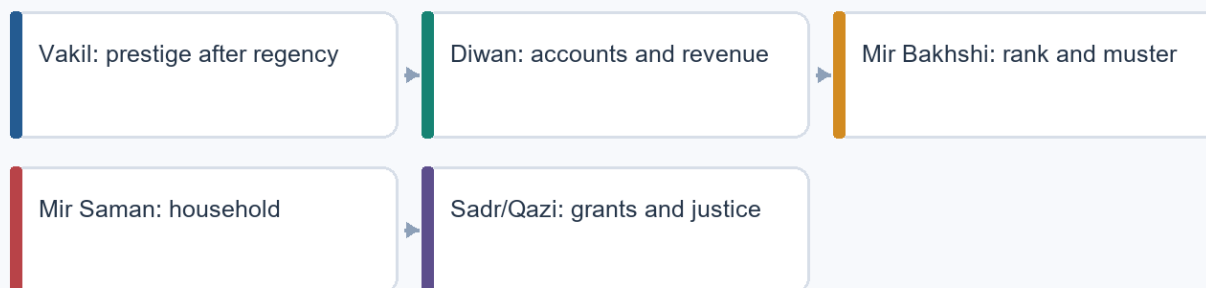
The mir saman or khan-i-saman directed the imperial household and karkhanas. Stores, workshops and supply were not decorative palace details: they supported the movable material world of court, campaign and gift. The sadr-us-sudur dealt with grants and connected religious/charitable functions; qazi-ul-quzat represented the highest judicial office. Their functions could overlap with political authority and grants, and the concentration of sadr power was curbed. Avoid presenting either as an independent modern welfare ministry or judiciary.

Office	Primary working field	Check or limit
Wakil	prestige, residual coordinating role	reduced after the regency lesson
Diwan	accounts, revenue, fiscal scrutiny	ruler and parallel officers remained decisive

Office	Primary working field	Check or limit
Mir bakhshi	mansabs, presentation, muster records	actual contingents still needed inspection
Mir saman	household, karkhanas, stores	served imperial rather than public-private separation
Sadr/qazi	grants and judicial-religious functions	authority was not constitutionally autonomous

TRAP: “Checks and balances” is usable only with the qualifier *ruler-centred*. It meant office differentiation, central appointment and cross-reporting—not modern separation of powers.

Central offices: distinct functions

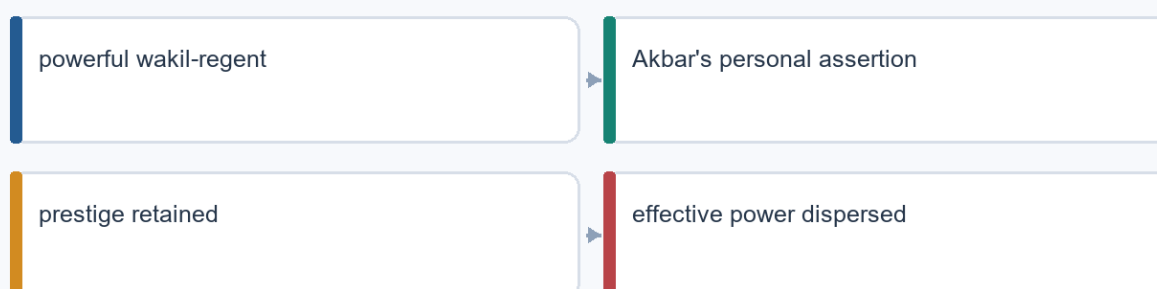


Use functional labels; do not convert offices into modern ministries.

VISUAL 05

Use functional labels; do not convert offices into modern ministries.

The Bairam Khan lesson



The office was constrained after experience of an over-mighty regency.

VISUAL 06

The office was constrained after experience of an over-mighty regency.

Diwan's fiscal workflow

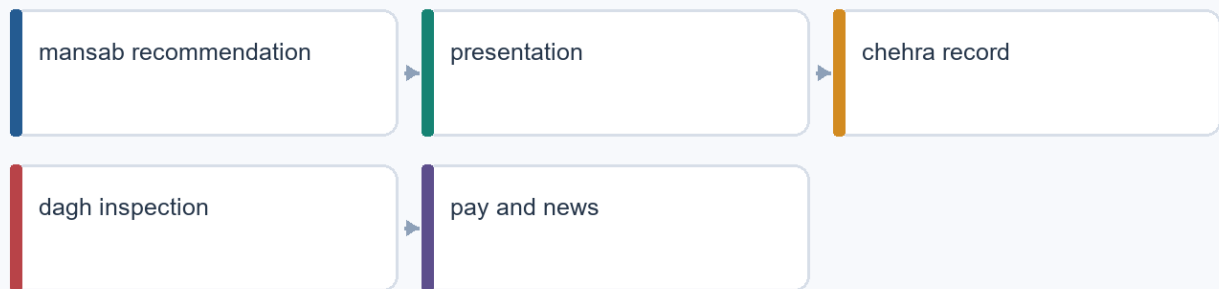


The diwan was a financial controller, not merely a collector.

VISUAL 07

The diwan was a financial controller, not merely a collector.

Mir Bakhshi: rank to muster

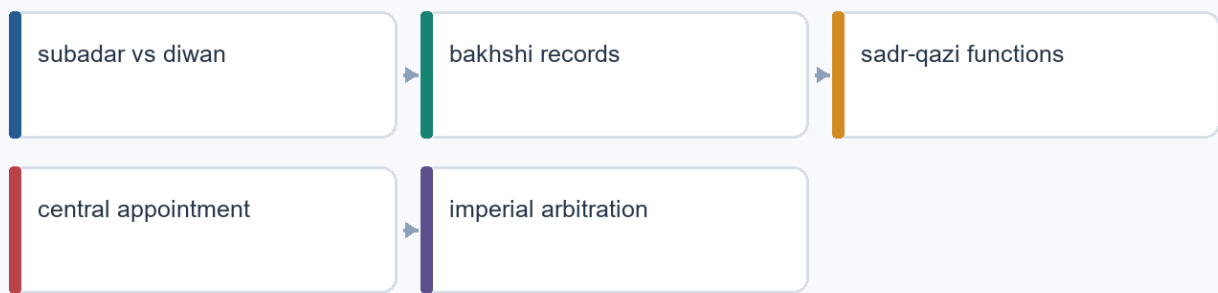


Military records and elite management were connected through the mansab.

VISUAL 08

Military records and elite management were connected through the mansab.

Checks, overlap and limits

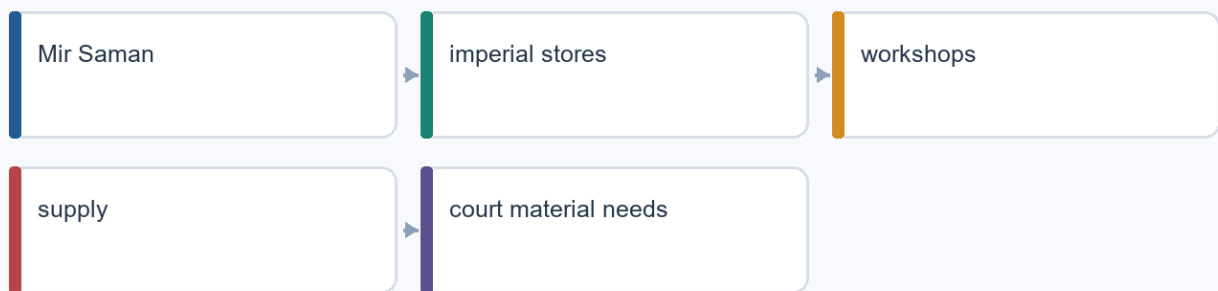


Checks prevented concentration but did not create independent constitutional branches.

VISUAL 09

Checks prevented concentration but did not create independent constitutional branches.

Household and karkhana capacity



Household administration was a material arm of imperial rule.

VISUAL 10

Household administration was a material arm of imperial rule.

Grant and justice functions



Religious/judicial functions should not be treated as a modern, autonomous judiciary.

VISUAL 11

Religious/judicial functions should not be treated as a modern, autonomous judiciary.

PART III — Province, district, pargana and village

In 1580 the empire was divided into twelve subas. At the provincial level a subadar (also described in relevant contexts as sipahsalar) was joined by a provincial diwan, bakhshi, sadr-qazi and reporting personnel. The design mattered: a governor did not independently own the fiscal apparatus, while the fiscal officer was not a military sovereign. Centrally appointed offices and separate reports were meant to restrain provincial consolidation. The practical strength of a subadar could nevertheless exceed a formal diagram; distance, local alliances and campaign conditions qualified the check.

The hierarchy was **suba -> sarkar -> pargana -> village**. It is a territorial scale, not a single chain of command in which every office did the same work. At a sarkar, faujdar and amil-guzar/amalguzar conventions need careful use: the former relates to coercive/military order, the latter to revenue work. A faujdar's jurisdiction was not always coterminous with a sarkar; terminology and reach could vary. At pargana level, shiqdar, amil, qanungo, potdar/treasurer and karkun/clerk appear in the record cluster. Their work made local assessment, memory, accounts and custody administratively visible.

Village government retained intermediaries. Muqaddams or patels, patwaris, chaudhuris, zamindars and customary bodies could mediate between cultivators and the fiscal machine. Panchayat and customary autonomy should therefore be stated as context-specific and source-grounded, not as a claim that the Mughal state was absent. Conversely, the claim that the state directly reached every cultivator in identical fashion is equally false. State demand travelled through records, local knowledge and unequal bargaining power.

Assignments are not ownership. Khalisa referred to revenues reserved for the crown; jagir to a state revenue assignment often used to meet a mansabdar's remuneration; and madad-i-maash/inam to grant arrangements. A jagir did not normally confer ownership of land, a hereditary feudal estate, or a sovereign province. A jagirdar and a zamindar occupied different positions: the former was commonly a transferable imperial assignee; the latter had local landed claims, social standing, often armed following, and a mediating role in collection.

Direct/owned PYQ — 2021 CSE Prelims GS-I, Q45

Exact wording verified from local UPSC question paper

books/more_previous_papers/QP-CSP-21-GeneralStudiesPaper-I-121021.pdf:

“With reference to medieval India, which one of the following is the correct sequence in ascending order in terms of size?”

(a) Paragana-Sarkar-Suba (b) Sarkar-Paragana-Suba (c) Suba-Sarkar-Paragana (d) Paragana-Suba-Sarkar

INFERRED ANSWER — NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED: (a), confidence high. The territorial ladder is pargana, then sarkar, then suba. Eliminate (b) because it reverses the first two units; (c) descends rather than ascends; and (d) puts suba below sarkar. The local official paper establishes the wording and original option order, but no official answer key is held locally, so the answer is deliberately not called official.

PYQ routing boundary: The 2019 Prelims jagirdar-zamindar question is owned by Topic 24 (Mughal Society, Economy and Culture). It is an adjacent conceptual link, not seized as a Topic 16 direct PYQ. The 2025 question on religious syncretism belongs to Topic 17. Searches of local 2018-25 CSE routing ledgers found no other direct, exact Topic 16 question to reproduce.

Provincial replication of the centre



Centrally appointed officers were designed to report and counterbalance.

VISUAL 12

Centrally appointed officers were designed to report and counterbalance.

Twelve subas in 1580

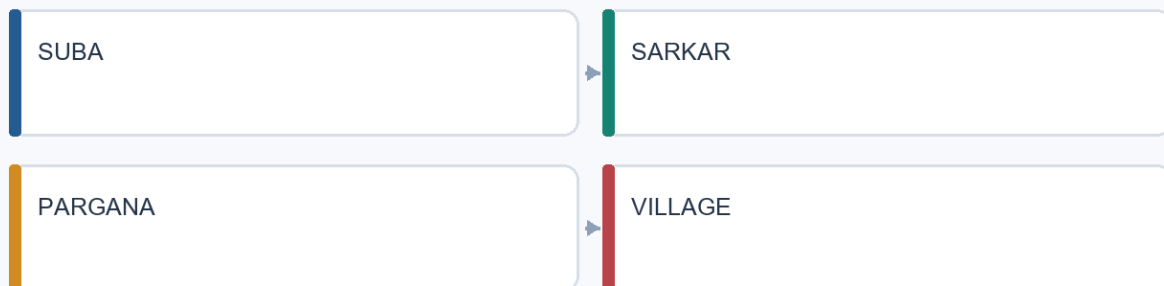


A schematic placement only; it illustrates a provincial grid, not modern boundaries.

VISUAL 13

A schematic placement only; it illustrates a provincial grid, not modern boundaries.

Administrative hierarchy



Ascending territorial size: pargana -> sarkar -> suba.

VISUAL 14

Ascending territorial size: pargana -> sarkar -> suba.

Provincial checks in practice

governor commands

diwan controls fiscal record

bakhshi tracks service

reports move upward

Formal separation could be weakened by local power and imperial distance.

VISUAL 15

Formal separation could be weakened by local power and imperial distance.

Sarkar: fiscal and coercive functions

faujdar: order and military force

amil-guzar: revenue administration

jurisdiction could vary

A faujdar's jurisdiction was not always identical with one sarkar.

VISUAL 16

A faujdar's jurisdiction was not always identical with one sarkar.

Pargana record cluster

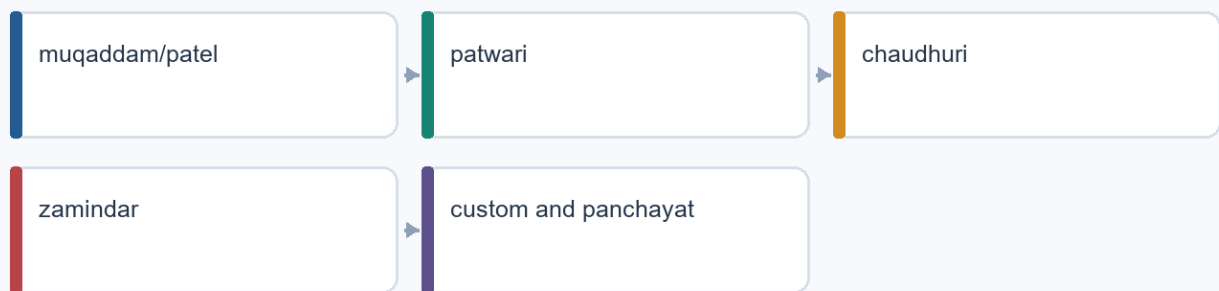


Local records and treasury work made assessment administratively possible.

VISUAL 17

Local records and treasury work made assessment administratively possible.

Village intermediaries and autonomy



The state did not uniformly transact with every cultivator directly.

VISUAL 18

The state did not uniformly transact with every cultivator directly.

Khalisa, jagir and inam

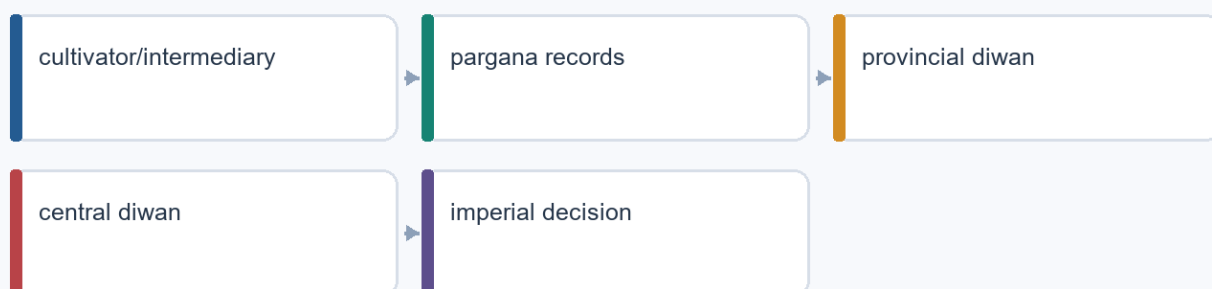


Different fiscal destinations did not turn assignments into sovereign territories.

VISUAL 19

Different fiscal destinations did not turn assignments into sovereign territories.

Administrative information flow



State capacity depended on records travelling as well as revenue travelling.

VISUAL 20

State capacity depended on records travelling as well as revenue travelling.

PART IV — Mansabdari: one hierarchy, several state problems

A *mansab* was a graded imperial rank. It conveyed status, salary/remuneration and service obligation; it did not describe merely a cavalry quota. The system created a single civil-military service world in which an officer's place in the courtly hierarchy, entitlement and expected usefulness were linked. Ranks began at 10. High ranks of 5000 and, exceptionally under Akbar, 7000 must be handled as markers of elevation rather than evidence of one fixed table operating unchanged across the reign.

Mansabdari also helped incorporate a composite ruling class: Turani, Irani, Indian Muslim, Rajput, Afghan and other elements could be placed in a common ranked framework. It supplied a language of imperial honour and a channel for promotion, demotion, patronage and surveillance. This does not erase social hierarchy, family advantage or faction. It is therefore wrong both to call every mansab a hereditary feudal title and to call the system a modern, impersonal

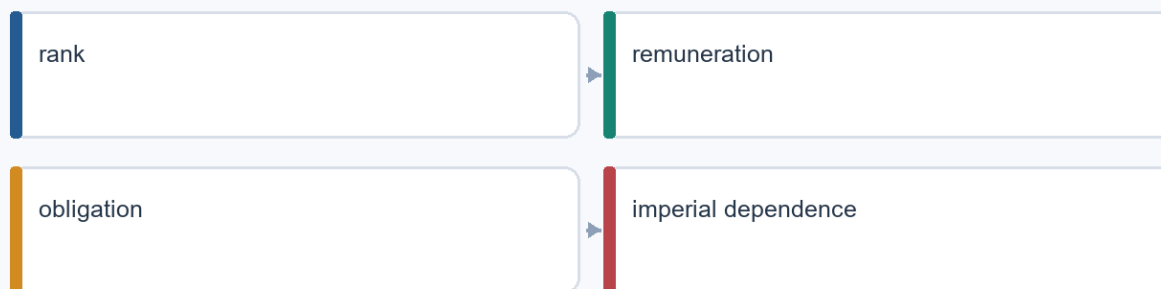
meritocracy.

The explicit two-part rank came late, in Akbar's fortieth regnal year (1595-96). *Zat* indicated personal rank, status and related pay; *sawar* indicated the cavalry obligation associated with the rank. This distinction was introduced to clarify dimensions of service and should not be projected unchanged to the early 1560s. Classifications of first, second and third class mansabdars are technical and have source-specific interpretations; an answer should explain the basic distinction before using such labels.

Payment could be cash or, often, a jagir assignment. The assessment figure (*jama*) and, where source-supported, dami valuation helped calculate an assignment; actual receipt (*hasil*) could fall below the paper figure. The jagir did not turn the assignee into the owner of every field or into a provincial sovereign. Transfers, review, promotion and dependency on imperial appointment discouraged a durable territorial base, but short tenure could encourage quick extraction. That tension is a seed of later problems, not a licence to narrate the full seventeenth-century jagirdari crisis here.

Why one institution solved multiple problems: a rank made diverse nobles comparable; a salary/service link attached privilege to obligation; jagir or cash payment enabled remuneration; and musters offered a way to test a claimed military resource. This is the integrative insight a Mains answer should foreground.

Mansab: status, salary and service

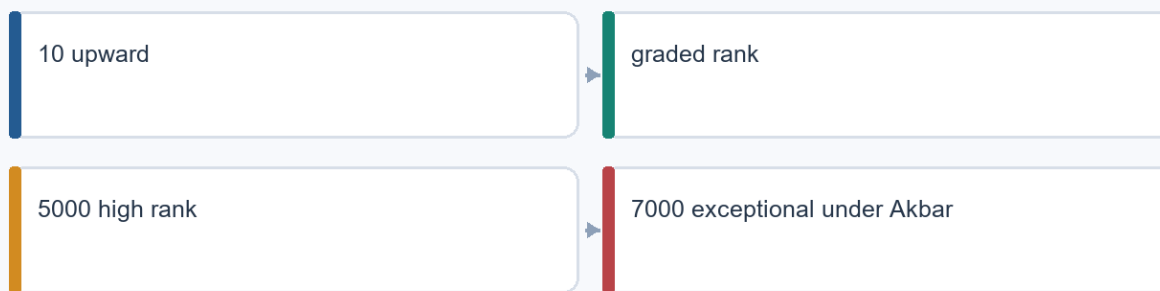


One graded service linked civil position, military duty and courtly status.

VISUAL 21

One graded service linked civil position, military duty and courtly status.

Mansab hierarchy

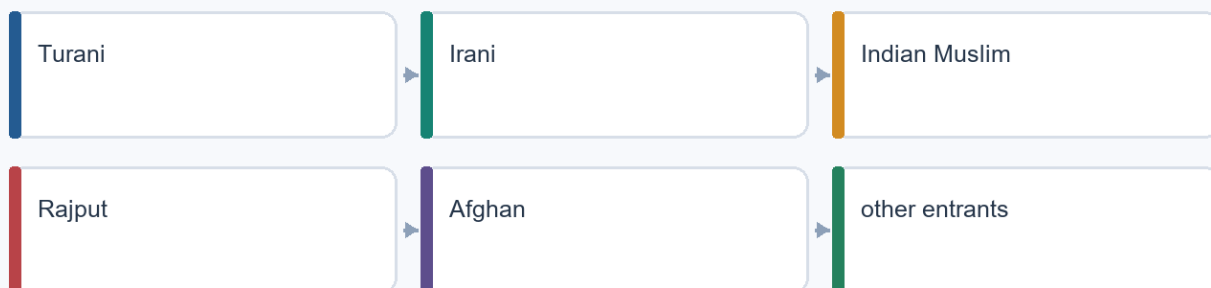


Do not imagine a fixed table unchanged throughout the reign.

VISUAL 22

Do not imagine a fixed table unchanged throughout the reign.

Composite ruling class



Recruitment integrated diverse elites without eliminating hierarchy or competition.

VISUAL 23

Recruitment integrated diverse elites without eliminating hierarchy or competition.

Zat and sawar after 1595-96

ZAT: personal status/pay

SAWAR: cavalry obligation

late distinction

not one early fixed form

A distinction in rank clarified two different dimensions of service.

VISUAL 24

A distinction in rank clarified two different dimensions of service.

Mansabdari's staged evolution

1567 hierarchy

1573-74 inspection

1595-96 dual rank

later expansion

Later Mughal developments must not be projected backward onto early Akbar.

VISUAL 25

Later Mughal developments must not be projected backward onto early Akbar.

Salary, service and imperial authority

mansab

pay scale

service expectation

review and promotion

Rank was an imperial instrument of social ordering and obligation.

VISUAL 26

Rank was an imperial instrument of social ordering and obligation.

Cash pay and jagir payment

cash salary possible

jagir commonly assigned

jama valuation

collection realities

A jagir was a way of meeting remuneration, not a grant of private land.

VISUAL 27

A jagir was a way of meeting remuneration, not a grant of private land.

Jagirdar versus zamindar

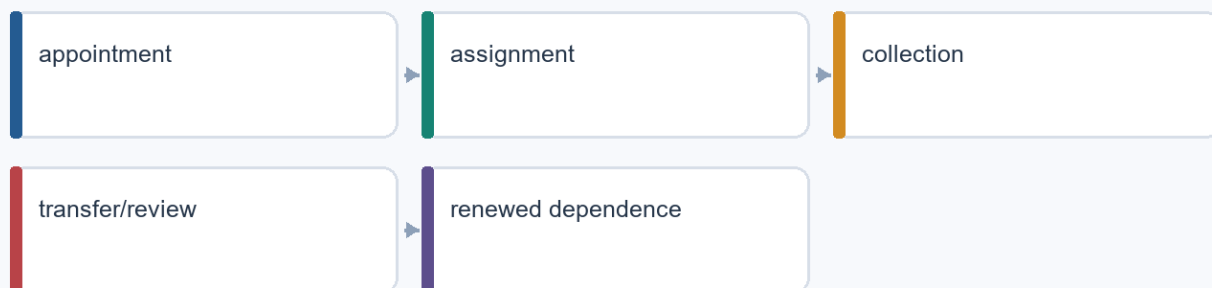


The two terms refer to different relationships with revenue and locality.

VISUAL 28

The two terms refer to different relationships with revenue and locality.

Transfer and dependence cycle



Transfer restrained territorial roots but encouraged short-term extraction.

VISUAL 29

Transfer restrained territorial roots but encouraged short-term extraction.

PART V — Dagħ, chehra, army and information

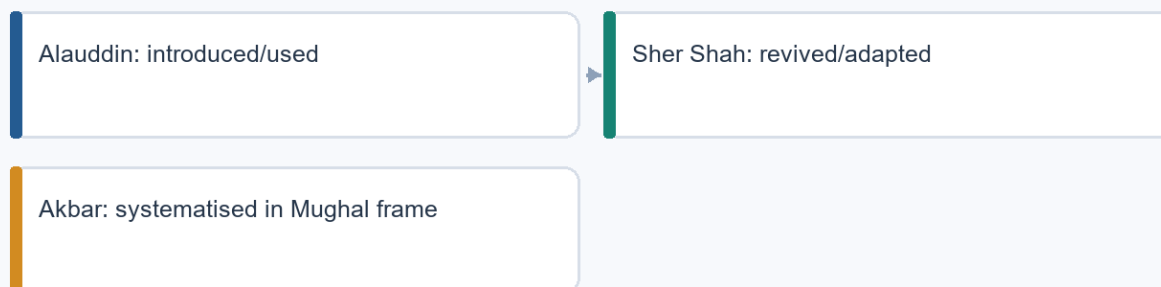
Dagħ was horse branding and *chehra* a descriptive roll of soldiers. Their provenance is a high-value factual trap. Alauddin Khalji introduced/used these forms of control; Sher Shah revived or adapted them; Akbar systematised or reintroduced them within the Mughal framework. Akbar did not invent them from nothing. The owner source places the Akbar-era introduction of dagħ in the eighteenth regnal year, 1573-74. Its purpose was to narrow the gap between paper claims and actual horses/men, deter substitution and give the court a record for inspection.

Inspection had costs and effects. Nobles could resist a device that made their claims more visible; officers could harass those being verified; evasion and imperfect compliance persisted. Thus dagħ and chehra demonstrate both administrative intent and the limits of enforcing paperwork. Writing that they “completely eliminated corruption” is as wrong as calling them irrelevant.

The imperial military was not a modern uniform national standing army. It combined mansabdar contingents with ahadis and, where source-grounded, artillery, infantry, elephants and centrally maintained elements. Cavalry remained central. The mir bakhshi's records linked rank and military personnel, but direct imperial control was mediated by officers, supply, review and local conditions.

News writers such as waqia-navis, and relevant sawanih/secret reporting terminology when context permits, indicate that information was an administrative resource. The safe connection is that the court sought reports and the mir bakhshi's field included intelligence/news in the source account. Avoid inventing a single modern intelligence agency with uniform reach. Justice and policing likewise mixed emperor, qazi, faujdar, kotwal and local institutions; they did not deliver uniform rule of law in the modern sense. Coercion, hierarchy, discretion and local mediation qualify any simple centralisation narrative.

Dagh and chehra: a continuity timeline

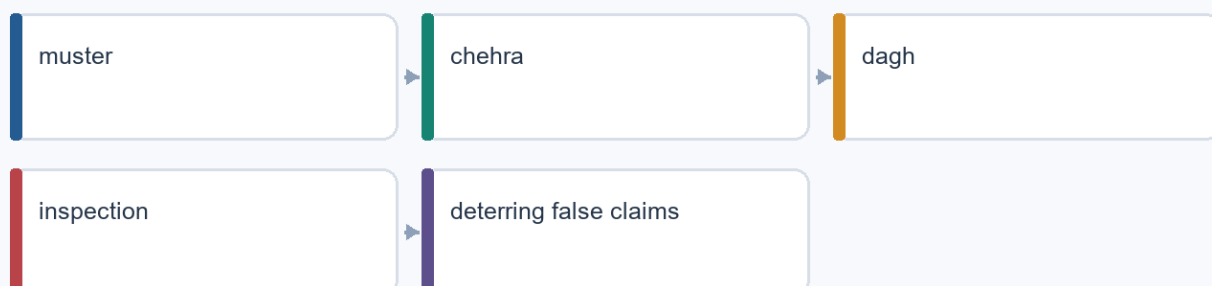


Akbar did not invent horse branding or descriptive rolls from nothing.

VISUAL 30

Akbar did not invent horse branding or descriptive rolls from nothing.

Horse and soldier verification

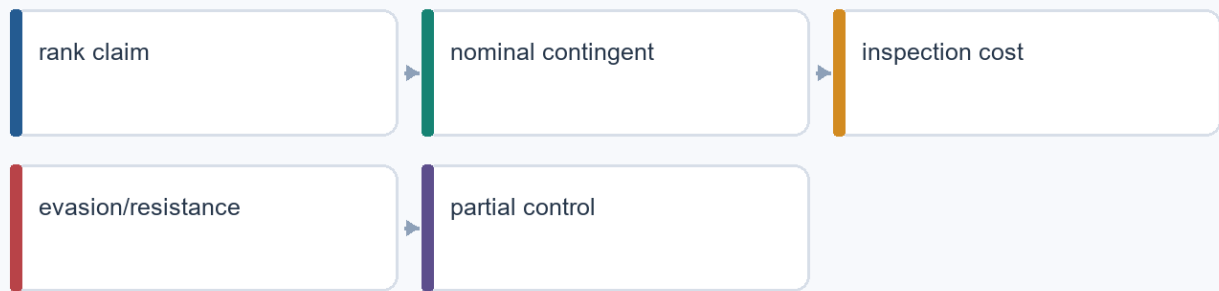


Controls targeted the gap between sanctioned contingents and present troops.

VISUAL 31

Controls targeted the gap between sanctioned contingents and present troops.

Paper troop versus actual troop problem

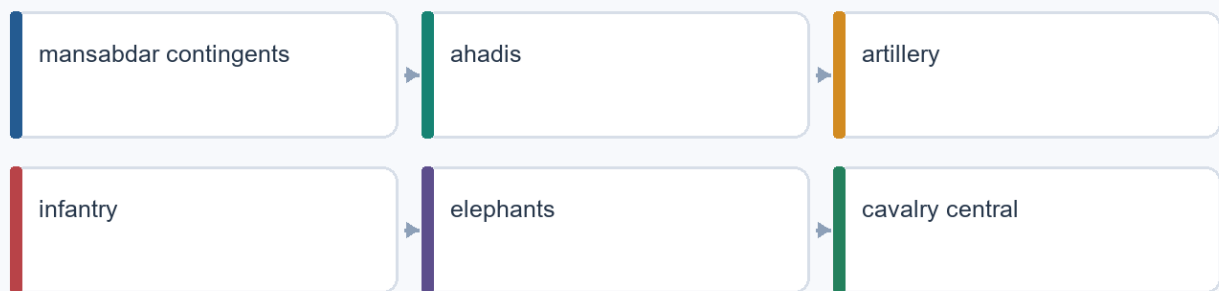


Verification improved oversight but could not erase evasion or harassment.

VISUAL 32

Verification improved oversight but could not erase evasion or harassment.

Imperial military composition

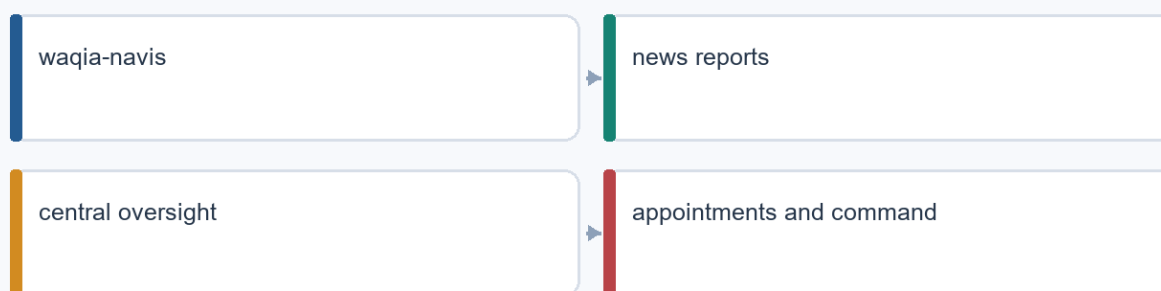


This was not a modern national standing army with a single uniform payroll.

VISUAL 33

This was not a modern national standing army with a single uniform payroll.

News and intelligence network



Information reinforced supervision; terminology and reach varied by context.

VISUAL 34

Information reinforced supervision; terminology and reach varied by context.

PART VI — Revenue: purpose, experimentation and the dahsala mechanism

Akbar's fiscal objective was predictable imperial claim: financing court, campaigns, remuneration and household; learning about cultivation; and controlling officials and intermediaries. It was not a peasant-welfare scheme alone. A better formulation is that predictability could reduce arbitrary assessment while still serving extraction. Crops, transport, local prices, cesses, official coercion and risk affected the burden faced by cultivators.

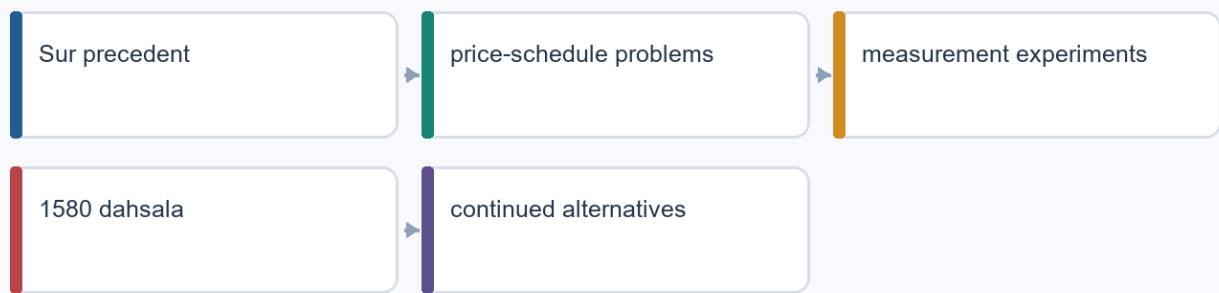
Sher Shah's precedents supplied measurement, record and control lessons. Akbar's administration tried central price schedules but encountered a problem: court-centred prices could be delayed or ill suited to regional productivity and market conditions. The reforms moved towards local price/productivity circles and more usable assessment. Muzaffar Khan Turbati, Todar Mal and Shah Mansur must be named as a team, not reduced to a "Todar Mal-only genius" story.

Zabti is measurement-based assessment. **Dahsala**, implemented in 1580, used averages of produce and prices over ten years to inform assessment; the theoretical state share is often expressed as one-third of average produce, converted into cash. The terms overlap in a revenue discussion but are not synonyms. Dahsala is not a permanent ten-year settlement: the ten years describe the averaging data, not an immutable tenure granted to a peasant or village. Cash payment was encouraged/required in the zabt framework, yet kind arrangements and other methods remained in use.

Measurement used a *jarib*, often described as bamboo linked with iron rings, to reduce stretching. It is a useful evidence point for standardisation, not a warrant to assign one universal modern area value to every historical bigha. Crop rates (*dastur*) and locally framed practice turned measured area and estimated yield into a demand. Do not mix categories from different systems merely because both concern land.

The land labels polaj, parati/parauti, chachar and banjar refer broadly to cultivation frequency and fallow history. They are not simply a four-step fertility scale. Good, middling and bad yield classifications should be used only in their correct analytical setting; do not merge them with these cultivation labels as if all are identical.

Revenue reform chronology

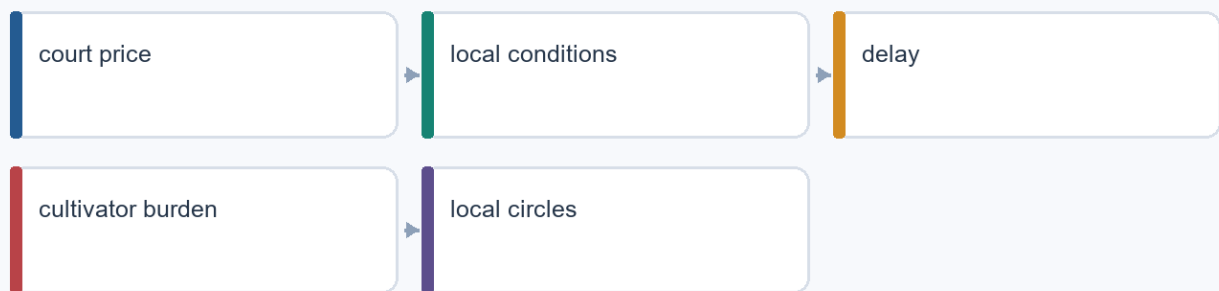


Dahsala was an outcome of experiments, not a first-day decree.

VISUAL 35

Dahsala was an outcome of experiments, not a first-day decree.

Why central price schedules disappointed

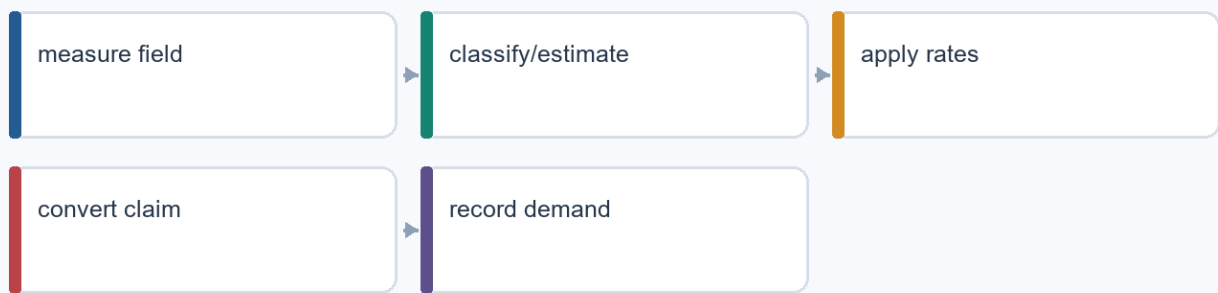


A uniform central schedule could fail where price and productivity varied locally.

VISUAL 36

A uniform central schedule could fail where price and productivity varied locally.

Zabti: measurement-based assessment

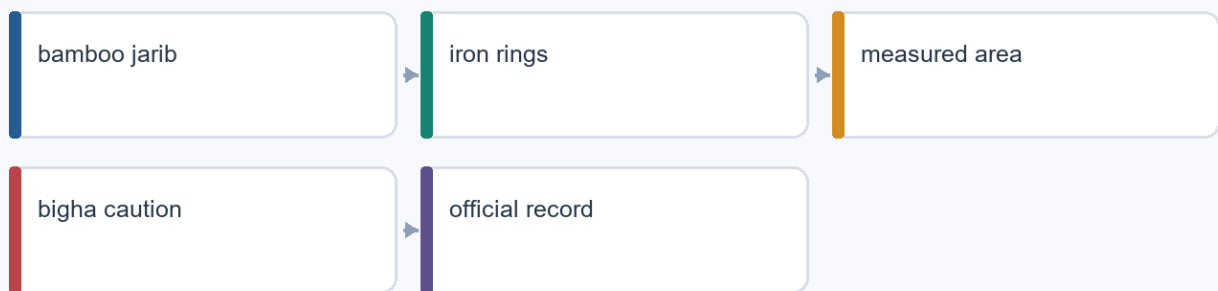


Zabti names a measurement-based mode; it is not identical to every ten-year average.

VISUAL 37

Zabti names a measurement-based mode; it is not identical to every ten-year average.

Jarib and bigha: standardisation with caution

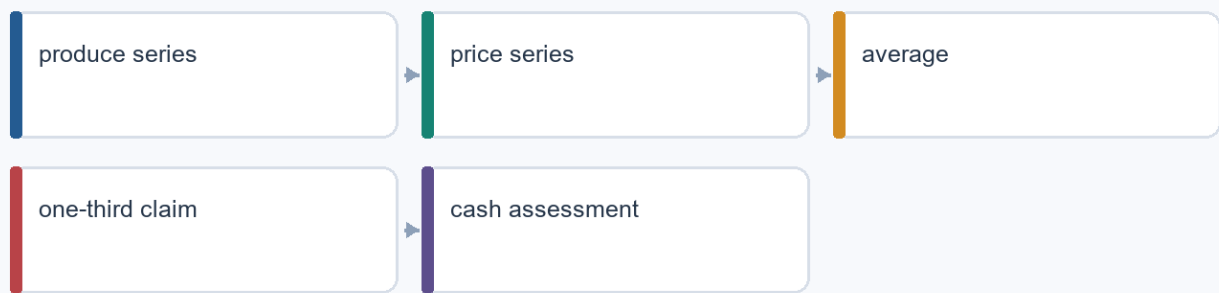


Standardisation served administration, but historical land measures require local caution.

VISUAL 38

Standardisation served administration, but historical land measures require local caution.

Dahsala: ten-year averaging

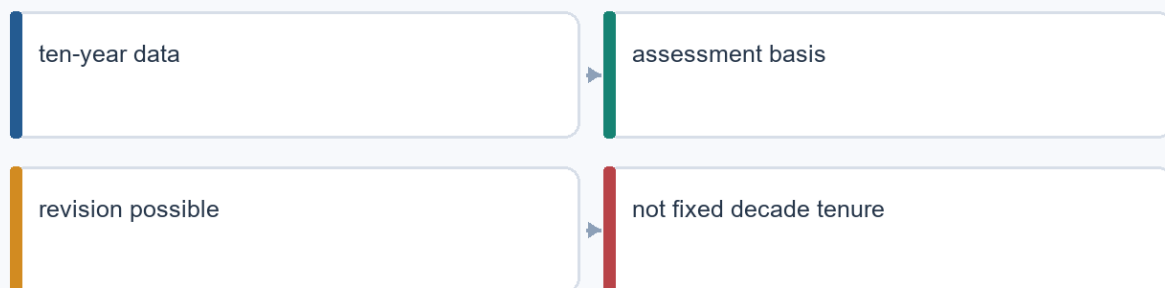


The average was a calculation for assessment, not a permanent ten-year contract.

VISUAL 39

The average was a calculation for assessment, not a permanent ten-year contract.

Dahsala is not a ten-year settlement



The word 'ten' concerns the averaging window, not immutable settlement duration.

VISUAL 40

The word 'ten' concerns the averaging window, not immutable settlement duration.

Land categories by cultivation history



These are cultivation-frequency categories, not a simple fertile-to-infertile ladder.

VISUAL 41

These are cultivation-frequency categories, not a simple fertile-to-infertile ladder.

PART VII — Methods, geography, intermediaries and limits

The revenue repertoire explains why “Akbar imposed universal zabt everywhere” is wrong. Batai or ghalla-bakhshi was crop sharing in a fixed proportion; it could fit situations where output rather than a cash schedule was the workable base, but entailed division and supervision. Kankut combined measurement with inspection/appraisal of the standing crop; it is not merely a crop-share label. Nasaq relied substantially on previous assessment or payment and estimate, avoiding a full fresh measurement. Terrain, crop, records, staff and local conditions affected which mode was usable.

The basic source's safe geographic formulation places zabt/dahsala from Lahore to Allahabad and in Malwa and Gujarat. It must not become “all India” or “every field.” Bengal, Sindh, Kashmir and difficult tracts require care: where measurement and standardisation were difficult, alternatives and limits mattered. The very persistence of batai, kankut and nasaq is evidence of uneven capacity.

A revenue chain can be sketched as cultivator/local intermediary -> amil and record personnel -> provincial diwan -> central diwan. It was never a frictionless pipe. The difference between *jama* (assessed demand) and *hasil* (realised receipt) is crucial: a high paper assignment might not yield its nominal revenue. Zamindars were local landholders/claimants and mediators with social and at times armed power. They were not simply British-era landlords, nor were they eliminated by Mughal measurement.

Cash assessment joined revenue demand to currency, markets and circulation of agrarian surplus. It supports a discussion of monetisation, but regional unevenness prevents the claim of complete commercialisation. Remission for crop loss and, where securely grounded, taccavi assistance show that a fiscal state needed cultivation to continue. They do not prove a benevolent system: actual burdens could be intensified by price risk, officials, cesses and coercive collection.

Assessment methods compared

zabt: measure and rates

batai: share crop

kankut: measurement + estimate

nasaq: prior estimate

Choice varied with crop, terrain, records and administrative reach.

VISUAL 42

Choice varied with crop, terrain, records and administrative reach.

Batai / ghalla-bakhshi

harvest

share in fixed proportion

state receives kind/share

measurement less central

Crop sharing can fit uncertain output but raises supervision and division issues.

VISUAL 43

Crop sharing can fit uncertain output but raises supervision and division issues.

Kankut

field measurement

standing crop inspection

estimate output

assessment

Kankut combines measurement with appraisal; it is not simply a fixed crop share.

VISUAL 44

Kankut combines measurement with appraisal; it is not simply a fixed crop share.

Nasaq

previous demand/payment

estimate

avoid full fresh measurement

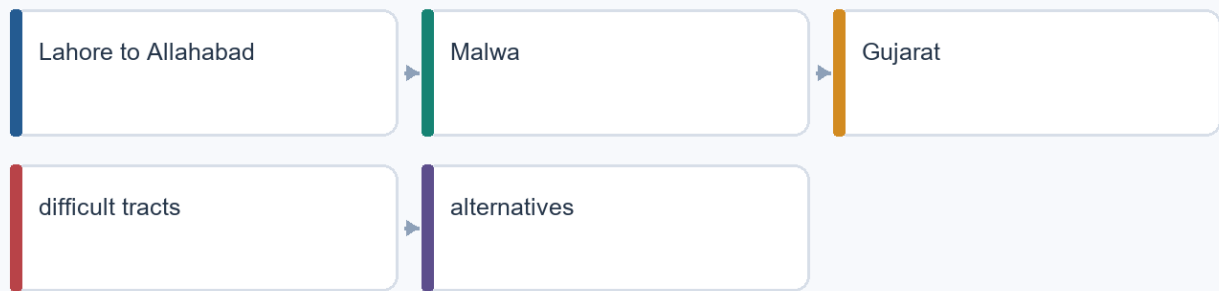
local practicality

Nasaq's estimate-based logic contrasts with a fresh, detailed zabt exercise.

VISUAL 45

Nasaq's estimate-based logic contrasts with a fresh, detailed zabt exercise.

Reach and limits of zabt/dahsala

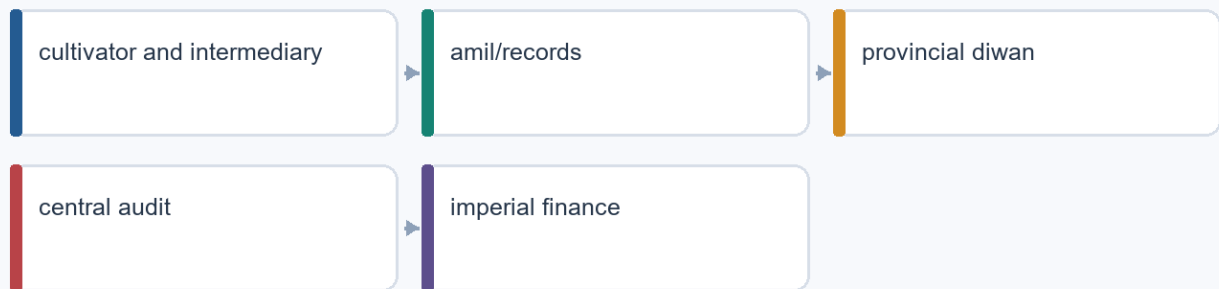


No claim that every province, field or crop fell under one uniform procedure.

VISUAL 46

No claim that every province, field or crop fell under one uniform procedure.

Revenue chain

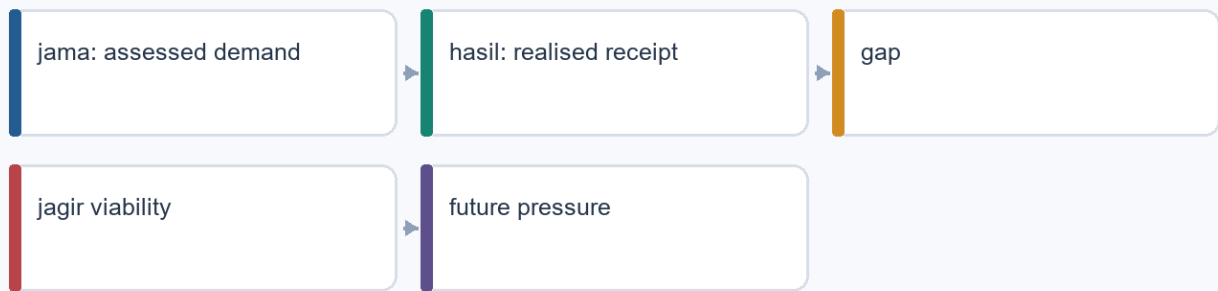


Collection was mediated by records and local actors, not a frictionless direct flow.

VISUAL 47

Collection was mediated by records and local actors, not a frictionless direct flow.

Jama and hasil

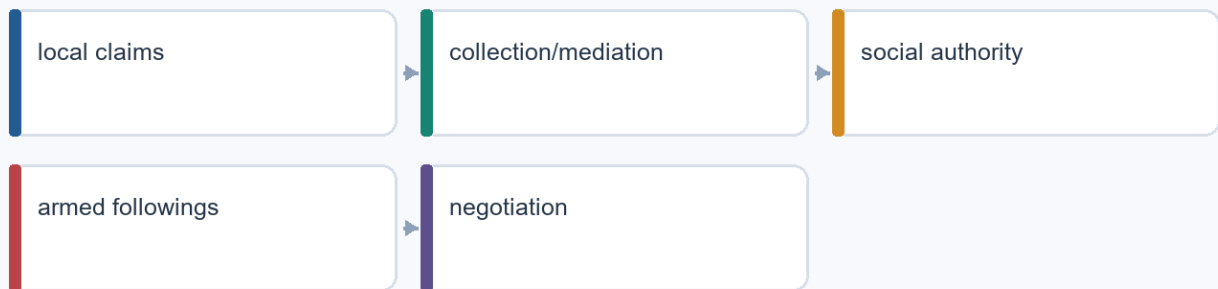


An assessed figure is not the same as cash or grain actually realised.

VISUAL 48

An assessed figure is not the same as cash or grain actually realised.

Zamindar as mediator and power holder

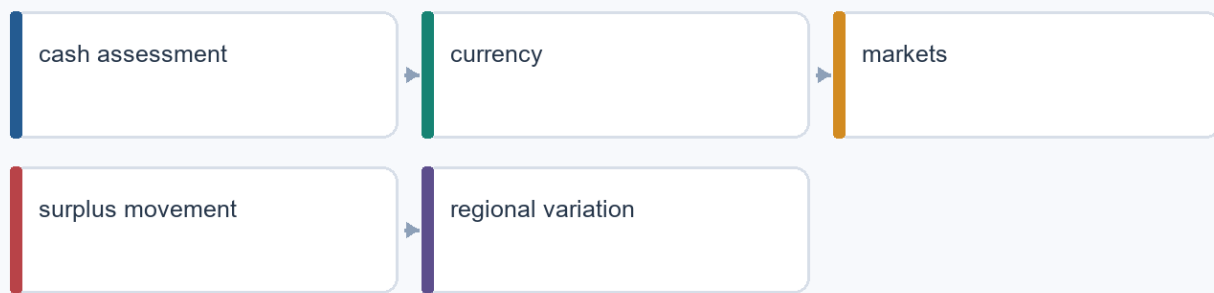


Measurement did not erase local landed power.

VISUAL 49

Measurement did not erase local landed power.

Cash nexus with uneven reach

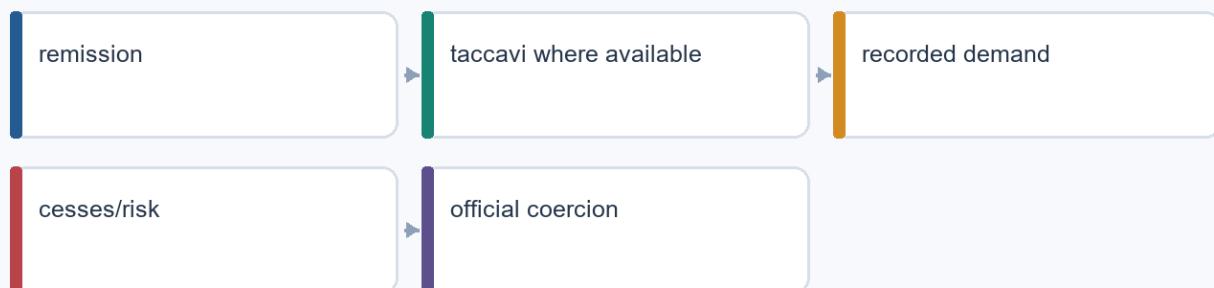


Monetisation is a tendency, not proof of complete commercialisation.

VISUAL 50

Monetisation is a tendency, not proof of complete commercialisation.

Safeguards and coercion



Fiscal rationality and peasant protection did not cancel extraction or vulnerability.

VISUAL 51

Fiscal rationality and peasant protection did not cancel extraction or vulnerability.

PART VIII — Comparison, sources and a balanced verdict

Comparing Sultanate iqta with Mughal jagir is an exercise in controlled similarity. Both involved assignment of revenue connected with service, but a strong answer examines tenure, transfer, fiscal base, audit, scale and degree of integration rather than announcing identity. Mughal jagir formed part of a more articulated mansab-salary hierarchy and a larger record system; this does not erase earlier Sultanate techniques. Topic 07 is the owner for the wider Sultanate administration and source-method module.

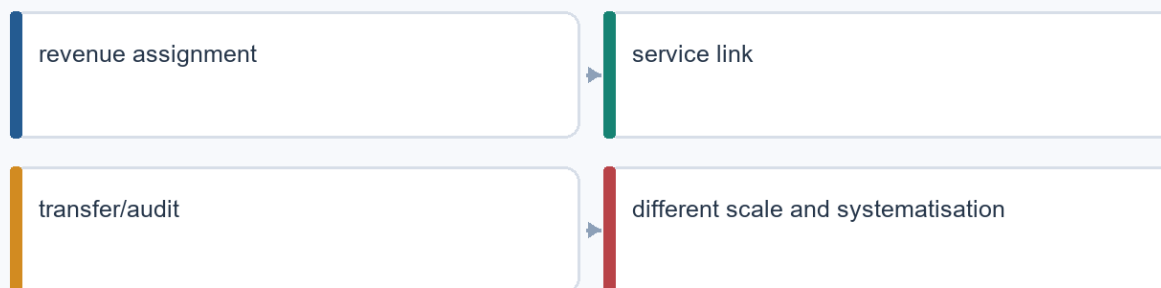
Sher Shah and Akbar likewise show continuity plus refinement. Sher Shah's measurement, roads, coins and control practices gave precedents; Akbar's team developed local rates, data averaging, fiscal offices and a larger imperial framework. Dagh/chehra must carry the correct Alauddin -> Sher Shah -> Akbar lineage. Akbar did not mechanically copy, and he did not begin every device.

The *Ain-i-Akbari*, within the Akbarnama project, is central but requires source criticism. It is an administrative compendium, a repository of figures and an account of ideal imperial order. Abu'l Fazl's patronage and praise make it extraordinarily useful for vocabulary, claimed regulations and the state's self-presentation, but not a census-like database or transparent report of every locality. Badauni provides a more hostile and sectarian perspective particularly where court/religious disagreement is relevant; hostility is not a shortcut to truth. Farmans, revenue records, coins, inscriptions and later historians can test different kinds of claim, each with its own archive and survival limits.

Source	Can help establish	Cannot alone establish
Ain-i-Akbari	administrative categories, official norms, compiled fiscal vision	universal implementation or precise modern-style census totals
Abu'l Fazl	imperial ideology and courtly justification	an unfiltered critical account of policy effects
Badauni	dissenting courtly/religious reaction	a neutral social survey
Farmans/records/coins	particular orders, transactions, circulation and claims	total lived experience without contextual reading

Overall verdict. Akbar's government was a high-capacity early modern imperial system because it linked office specialisation, rank, records, inspection, provincial replication and fiscal knowledge. Its checks were personal and hierarchical; its reach was uneven; local intermediaries, corruption, paper-versus-actual troops, cash-price risks and jagir incentives remained. The most accurate conclusion is neither “perfect centralisation” nor “mere medieval disorder,” but ambitious systematisation constrained by the conditions it sought to govern.

Iqta and jagir: comparison

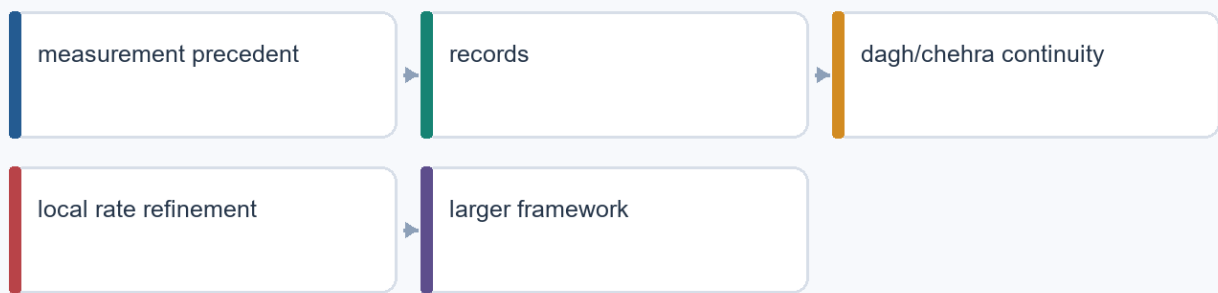


Avoid both false equivalence and the claim that Akbar invented assignment.

VISUAL 52

Avoid both false equivalence and the claim that Akbar invented assignment.

Sher Shah and Akbar

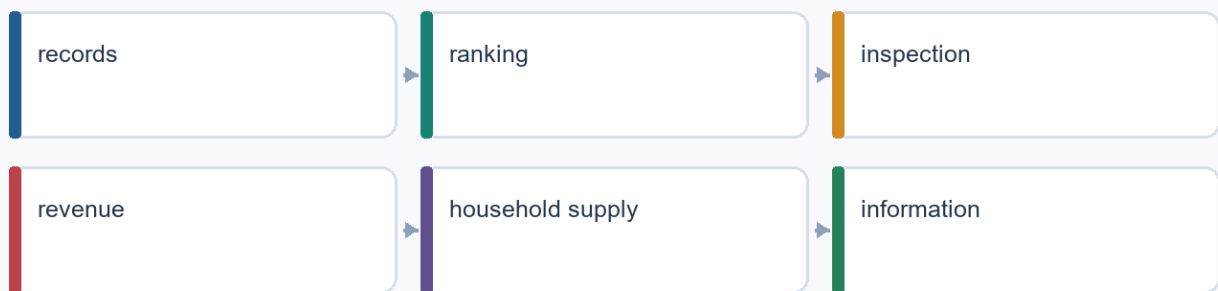


Akbar refined and coordinated earlier practices rather than mechanically copying them.

VISUAL 53

Akbar refined and coordinated earlier practices rather than mechanically copying them.

State capacity as a connected system

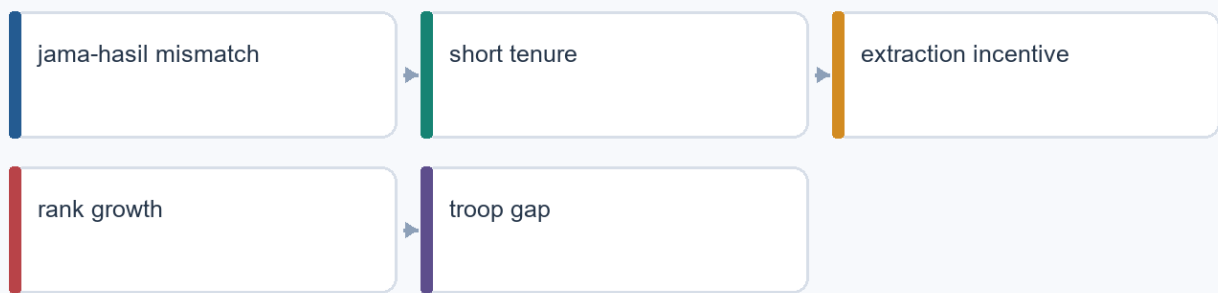


Capacity was a bundle of practices, not an abstract label for centralisation.

VISUAL 54

Capacity was a bundle of practices, not an abstract label for centralisation.

Structural-limit feedback loop

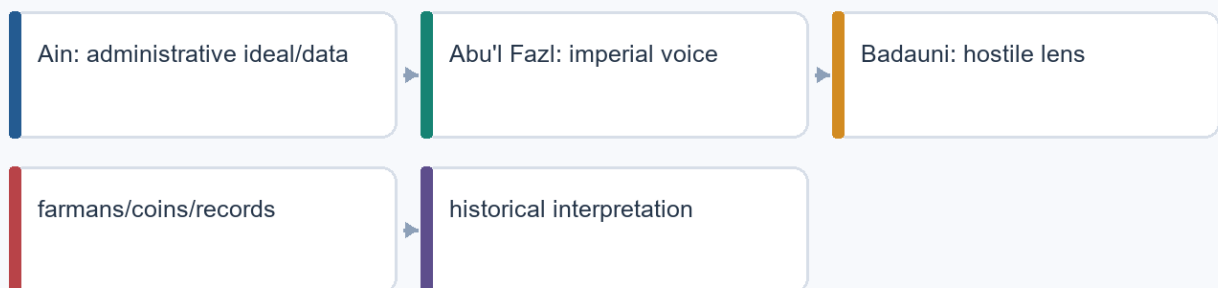


These were seeds of later strain, not a claim that a full crisis existed under Akbar.

VISUAL 55

These were seeds of later strain, not a claim that a full crisis existed under Akbar.

Sources and their reach

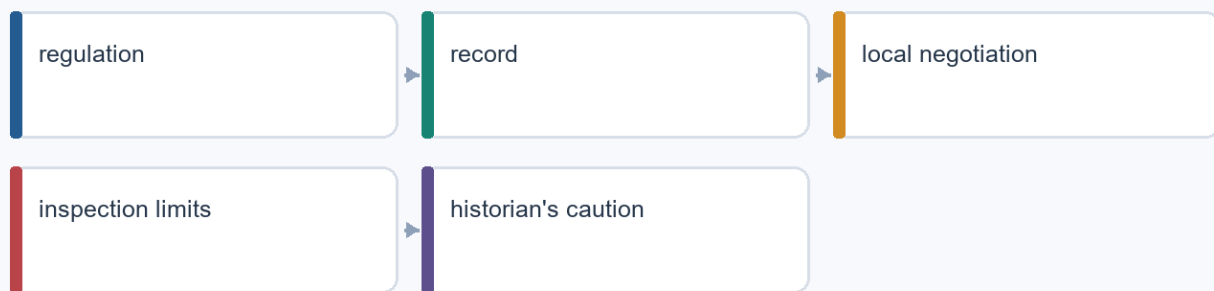


Evidence must be matched to the claim it can and cannot sustain.

VISUAL 56

Evidence must be matched to the claim it can and cannot sustain.

Norm versus practice

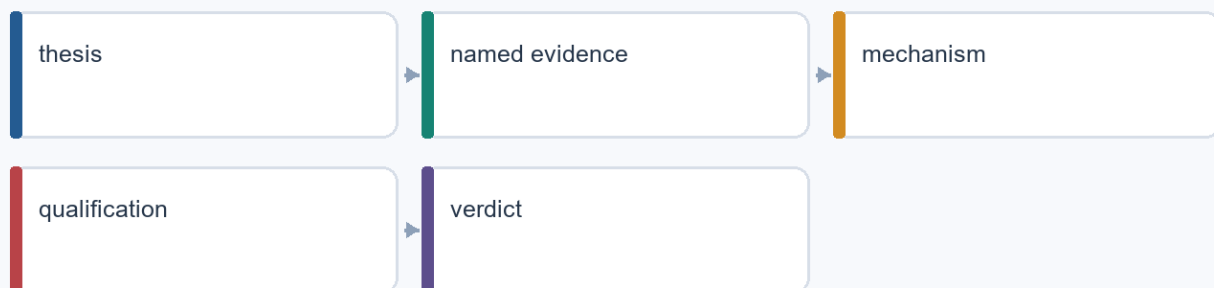


A rule in a compendium is not automatically a measured description of every locality.

VISUAL 57

A rule in a compendium is not automatically a measured description of every locality.

Mains answer spine



Use claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification rather than fact lists.

VISUAL 58

Use claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification rather than fact lists.

PART IX — How institutions changed within Akbar's reign

A chronology is not decoration in this topic; it is the protection against teleology. Akbar did not receive a readymade “Mughal administrative system” in 1556 and merely activate it. At accession the powerful Bairam Khan regency made the *wakil* politically central. The later decision to curb the office's effective power is therefore a response to experience, not an abstract preference for a modern cabinet. From the mid-1560s, the diwan's position was strengthened as imperial income, expenditure, assignments and provincial reports demanded specialised fiscal attention. The careers of Muzaffar Khan Turbati, Todar Mal and Shah Mansur should be used as evidence of expertise circulating through offices, not as a list of isolated “great men.”

The numerical mansab hierarchy is generally associated with 1567, but a rank system only becomes a more effective service instrument when the court can connect it to payment, presentation and verification. Dagh in 1573-74 and the

later zat-sawar distinction in 1595-96 are thus not loose additions. They show efforts to specify the resource behind rank: first, a capacity to test horses and soldiers; later, a way to distinguish personal courtly standing from cavalry obligation. A high-quality answer makes this sequence causal: enlargement of the elite and army exposed ambiguity and evasion, which prompted refinements.

Revenue reform follows the same pattern. Sher Shah's practices were useful precedents, yet early central price schedules created problems when local price and productivity did not fit a courtly schedule. The move to circles, measurement and averaged data reflects an information problem. The 1580 dahsala and suba reorganisation should consequently be read together: a larger territorial grid and a more intelligible assessment rule enabled better accounting, but neither guaranteed uniform implementation. The survival of batai, kankut and nasaq is evidence of adaptation, not a footnote that cancels the reform.

A useful answer skeleton is **problem -> administrative response -> gain -> limit**. Bairam Khan's dominance -> curbed wakil -> less concentrated ministerial power -> no constitutional separation. Nominal cavalry claims -> dagh/chehra -> better inspection -> resistance, cost and evasion. Variable yields/prices -> measurement and dahsala -> more predictable fiscal claim -> uneven reach and cash risk. This method turns chronology into analysis instead of merely reciting dates.

ANALYSIS: Later maturity must be kept separate from early experimentation. Do not say that zat-sawar existed in fixed form from 1556, or that every province received identical zabt after 1580.

PART X — Mansabdari as social architecture and operational problem

Mansabdari arranged a courtly social universe as much as it organised military service. A mansab expressed comparative proximity to the emperor: it located an officer within a visible hierarchy of precedence, honour, pay and expected usefulness. That function helped make a composite ruling class governable. Turanis, Iranis, Indian Muslims, Rajputs, Afghans and other entrants did not become socially identical; their histories, networks and political resources remained significant. What the shared rank did was furnish a common idiom through which imperial favour could be distributed and rivalry administratively processed.

This helps explain why “civil” and “military” should not be separated with modern labels. A mansabdar could be used in administration and was also assessed in terms of service resources. The rank was an imperial relationship, not a job title confined to a ministry. Conversely, do not turn every holder into a professional officer selected through open competitive examination. Recruitment through patronage, kinship, political accommodation and imperial confidence mattered. An anti-feudal answer must still acknowledge elite family advantage; a pro-centralisation answer must still acknowledge personal dependence and hierarchy.

Jagir payment converted a fiscal claim into a way of supporting this ranked service. Because state revenue rather than land title was assigned, reassignment could follow the mansabdar's career. Transfer was a political technology: it reduced the chance that one noble would make a permanent local base synonymous with his office. Yet it created a different operational problem. An assignee with uncertain tenure could value rapid realisation over long-term local improvement. If nominal jama exceeded obtainable hasil, the mismatch was not simply an accounting detail; it pressed on relationships with cultivators and intermediaries. This is the correct way to identify later-crisis seeds while respecting the Topic 21/25 ownership boundary for the seventeenth-century crisis.

Verification did not solve this entirely. Dagh and chehra sought to translate a military promise into inspectable horses and persons. A muster record can expose some misrepresentation, but it consumes time and administrative effort, and can generate avoidance or harassment. The **paper-versus-actual** gap is therefore an analytic theme: it appears in cavalry contingents and has a revenue counterpart in jama-versus-hasil. In both cases the state used records to make resources legible, but records were not the same as realised capacity.

Dimension	What mansabdari supplied	What it could not eliminate
Elite integration	common graded language of favour and service	faction, kinship, regional identity
Military claim	cavalry obligation and muster record	nominal/actual troop divergence
Remuneration	cash or jagir-linked support	jama-hasil shortfall

Dimension	What mansabdari supplied	What it could not eliminate
Central control	transfer, promotion, demotion	local extraction incentives

PART XI — Revenue as information: reconstructing the fiscal calculation

The best way to understand dahsala is as an attempt to transform scattered agrarian realities into an administratively usable claim. The state needed a chain of knowledge: area had to be measured or otherwise estimated; crop conditions had to be understood; rates had to relate assessment to local productivity and prices; a demand had to be entered; and the return had to travel through pargana and provincial records to the central diwan. Each stage could fail, be negotiated or be distorted. That is why a textbook definition must become a process explanation in a Mains answer.

Step one: establish a base. Under zabti, the jarib and its anti-stretching association with bamboo and iron rings signify an effort to standardise measurement. Standardising the instrument is not proof that every bigha was identical in every region; historical measures must retain local caution. Land labels polaj, parati/parauti, chachar and banjar orient the official to cultivation/fallow history. They do not themselves deliver a universal yield number or a simple fertility ranking.

Step two: translate agrarian output into a fiscal rate. Dahsala used a ten-year average of produce and prices. The analytical point is smoothing: a single exceptional season or price may be less decisive than a series. The theoretical one-third claim, commonly stated in cash after conversion, made revenue portable for imperial finance. Yet it also linked the payer to price and market conditions. A cash demand could be predictable in a record, while still difficult when local realisation, transport or prices did not cooperate.

Step three: recognise method choice. Where full measurement and a cash-rate schedule were unsuitable, batai shared crop, kankut combined measurement with crop appraisal, and nasaq drew heavily on previous assessment/payment. These alternatives should not be written as accidental deviations from a pure model. They reveal a fiscal administration that made choices under constraints of terrain, crop, staff, information and political bargaining.

Step four: distinguish a claim from a receipt. Jama is the sanctioned assessment; hasil is the realised return. This distinction makes the revenue chain dynamic. An amil, qanungo, local intermediary or jagirdar could confront harvest uncertainty, resistance, inadequate records or a high paper estimate. The central state did not “see” a field directly merely because a schedule existed.

MEMORY: Measure -> know/estimate -> set rate -> enter jama -> realise hasil -> audit/revise. The arrows contain negotiation and risk at every point.

PART XII — Peasants, intermediaries and the ethics of fiscal predictability

It is tempting to cast revenue reform as either benevolent modernisation or unrelieved oppression. Both shortcuts fail. Predictable procedures could reduce an official's scope for arbitrary reassessment and could tell cultivators and intermediaries more clearly what was claimed. Measurement, recorded rates and a ten-year average could supply a language for contestation as well as collection. Remission after crop failure, and assistance described in source-grounded contexts, indicate that the regime had an interest in restoring cultivation rather than destroying its own revenue base.

But a rational fiscal technique still aims at extraction. The court required resources for military service, household, patronage and administration. A theoretical share stated in cash did not automatically equal the social burden in a locality. Cesses, costs of transport, price fluctuation, access to markets, pressure from collectors and unequal bargaining power could alter the experienced burden. A prudent answer uses the term “predictability” rather than “welfare” as the primary policy objective.

Local intermediaries make this ethical and political complexity visible. A patwari or qanungo could retain local knowledge essential to a record; a muqaddam, chaudhuri or zamindar could mediate demand, mobilise people or resist it. Their agency means the imperial state did not simply stand outside village society, but it also means a cultivator did not meet an abstract rational state alone. Social power and local armed capacity shaped how a formal

demand was realised.

The same caution disciplines modern analogies. Today's land-record systems may be used to clarify measurement, map-making or audit as a problem of state capacity. They cannot make Mughal assessment equivalent to a legally conclusive property title, an elected government's welfare delivery, or an accountable tax administration. The relevant comparison is narrow and functional: both need information; their legal worlds and accountability structures are radically different.

Balanced Mains line: "Dahsala increased the legibility and predictability of the imperial claim, but did not dissolve the coercion, market risk and layered mediation through which that claim reached cultivators." This answers fiscal capacity and peasant experience without inventing a universal welfare outcome.

PART XIII — Source criticism as an administrative skill

Administrative history is unusually vulnerable to over-reading official texts. An orderly table of ranks or revenues looks modern to a reader, and its numerical detail can create a false sense of total coverage. The Ain-i-Akbari is valuable precisely because it gives a rich official language of offices, provincial units, categories, resources and fiscal aspiration. It permits historians to ask what the court wanted to count, rank and regulate. It cannot by itself establish that every recorded norm reached every locality with equal precision.

Abu'l Fazl's place in an imperial literary project matters. Praise of Akbar and an ideal of ordered sovereignty do not render the work false; they define its genre and purpose. A statement about the organisation of a department is strong evidence for the state's stated repertoire. A universal claim about peasant outcomes or actual troop strength needs corroboration. The move from a norm to a practice is an inference, and should be flagged as such.

Badauni is a useful counter-voice where courtly and religious disagreement is relevant, but the corrective is not automatic. His hostility and sectarian position make him evidence of dissenting perception, not a neutral equivalent of a spreadsheet. Farmans can establish particular commands or grants; revenue records can illuminate a surviving transaction or procedure; coins can indicate circulation and sovereignty; inscriptions can identify claims or patronage. Each source is partial, geographically uneven and survives by accident as well as design.

Source criticism also prevents a bad use of diagrams. A visual of suba -> sarkar -> pargana -> village captures an official territorial logic. It does not prove that the same officers operated with identical capacity in Bengal, Kashmir, a forest tract and an irrigated plain. A visual of dagh/chehra captures intended verification; it does not measure compliance. The historian must repeatedly ask: **what can this source prove, what does it merely claim, and what independent trace could qualify it?**

Final historiographical verdict. Akbar's state capacity is best assessed as evidence-backed ambition with genuine institutional effects and non-trivial limits. This protects against both imperial eulogy and a scepticism that treats all records as empty rhetoric.

PART XIV — Reading central offices through flows rather than labels

An office-list answer becomes analytical only when it follows a flow. Consider a proposed mansab. The sovereign's patronage makes appointment possible; the mir bakhshi handles presentation and the personnel/muster side; rank generates a remuneration claim; the diwan must see its fiscal implications; payment may be cash or a jagir assignment; and later record, inspection and report can expose a discrepancy. No one arrow means that an office exercised exclusive modern departmental jurisdiction. Rather, the point of specialised offices is that a decision leaves more than one administrative trace.

A revenue example works similarly. Information from village and pargana record personnel reaches fiscal officials; the amil's collection function encounters cultivators and intermediaries; provincial and central diwan scrutiny links assessment to larger expenditure and assignment decisions. The subadar's political/military position cannot simply absorb the diwan's ledger without defeating the intended design. Thus a province is not a scaled-down modern state with a governor and cabinet. It is an imperial field in which centrally appointed officers carry partly distinct claims to information and authority.

The mir saman's household and karkhana function is particularly useful for escaping an overly narrow "administration equals tax" story. Imperial rule required stores, workshops, transport, gifts, clothing, weapons and courtly

consumption. A large court's material infrastructure became a source of patronage and command. It should not be romanticised as evidence of welfare administration, but it demonstrates that state capacity included logistics and material coordination.

Sadr and qazi functions require equal care. Grants and judicial-religious work rested within an imperial political order; later curbing of concentration in sadr power is evidence that grants had real political consequences. Yet neither "church-state separation" nor an independent judiciary describes the arrangement. The emperor's appointment, patronage and ultimate authority shape the field. A precise answer says **functional differentiation without institutional autonomy**.

This approach also clarifies overlap. The diwan's financial scrutiny could bear on jagirs supporting mansabdars; the mir bakhshi's records could bear on who claimed salary and service; central reporting could be used to supervise provincial officers. Overlap is not necessarily confusion. It can be an intentional way for a ruler to avoid dependence on a single official's version of revenue, troops or local politics. Its weakness is that coordination remains personal and may be slow, selective or vulnerable to court faction.

EXAM TEST: If a question asks "Was Akbar centralised?", write one sentence on the emperor, one on specialised flows, one on provincial replication, then one on local mediation and uneven practice. That sequence produces a verdict instead of a slogan.

PART XV — Comparative reasoning without false equivalence

Comparisons in medieval administration often fail because they seek a winner or a first inventor. A more reliable method fixes comparison columns: **resource assigned, office relationship, tenure/transfer, audit/record, military link, and local mediation**. With those columns, Sultanate iqta and Mughal jagir can be treated as related revenue-service arrangements while retaining different temporal settings, scale and systematisation. A response should avoid saying "iqta equals jagir" as readily as "Akbar created the first revenue assignment in India."

In an iqta discussion, Topic 07 remains the detailed owner for Sultanate administration. Topic 16's legitimate contribution is the later Mughal mechanism: jagir could meet a mansabdar's remuneration; it was checked by a diwan-oriented fiscal order and tied to a graded court service; transfer helped sustain imperial dependence. The comparison is strongest when it asks how a revenue claim was made governable, not when it replaces historical categories with "feudal" shorthand.

Sher Shah and Akbar require the same discipline. Sher Shah's measurement and record practices, road/sarai network and coin association form a Sur background. Akbar's administration shifted from experiments with central price schedules toward locally usable rates, a ten-year averaging procedure and a more elaborate provincial-fiscal framework. This is refinement and coordination. It is not a claim that one ruler simply copied the other, because policy responded to changing imperial extent, personnel and information needs.

Dagh and chehra are the test case for causal precision. "Alauddin introduced/used -> Sher Shah revived/adapted -> Akbar systematised within the Mughal framework" contains both continuity and change. It has a historical sequence, a technical function and a qualification: enforcement could be resisted and imperfect. A line such as "Akbar first introduced branding" loses marks because it confuses systematisation with invention.

Comparisons with modern institutions should be even more bounded. A rank can be compared to a personnel grade only to illuminate relative status and remuneration; it is not a transparent modern HR system. A jarib can be compared to a surveying instrument only to illuminate measurement; it is not a title registry. A provincial grid can be compared to administrative geography only to illuminate scale; it is not federalism. These boundaries are not pedantry: they protect causal reasoning from anachronism.

Comparative verdict: Akbar's achievement was less the appearance of isolated "new" devices than the more integrated coordination of inherited techniques through offices, rank, records and imperial supervision. The limits of implementation are part of that verdict, not an afterthought.

PART XVI — Technical traps: how an examiner turns vocabulary into elimination

Prelims questions on administration frequently pair two correct-sounding technical words and ask whether the candidate knows their level, function or chronology. The first defence is to sort terms into baskets. **Territory:** suba, sarkar, pargana, village. **Rank/service:** mansab, zat, sawar. **Revenue assignment and accounting:** khalisa, jagir, inam/madad-i-maash, jama, hasil. **Assessment methods:** zabti, dahsala, batai, kankut, nasaq. **Verification:** dagh, chehra. **Local actors:** amil, qanungo, muqaddam, patwari, zamindar. A statement crossing baskets wrongly is often eliminable.

The second defence is a date rule. If a question claims that zat-sawar came fully formed at the beginning of Akbar's reign, reject it: the explicit distinction is placed in 1595-96. If it names dagh as a 1580 revenue device, reject it: Akbar's owner-source date is 1573-74, and its function is military verification. If it calls dahsala an unchanging ten-year land settlement, reject it: 1580 marks implementation, while ten years describes an averaging technique. Chronology anchors concept.

The third defence is a verb rule. Jagir is **assigned**, not necessarily owned; jama is **assessed**, not realised; hasil is **realised**, not merely scheduled; a sawar quota is **obligated**, not automatically maintained in reality; the Ain **describes/claims** official order, not automatically proves universal practice. Verbs force the answer away from overly broad nouns.

The fourth defence is a scale rule. Pargana cannot be larger than suba, and a faujdar's active jurisdiction should not automatically be assumed identical to one named sarkar. An official at provincial level is not thereby a modern minister. A village intermediary does not automatically become an independent sovereign. Scale and function must be read together.

Finally, keep the closest distractor in view. The examiner rarely sets "unrelated" choices. Zabti and dahsala are close because both relate to assessment; batai and kankut are close because both engage crop/output; jagirdar and zamindar are close because both appear in revenue relations; diwan and mir bakhshi are close because service requires money and military personnel. State the one discriminator in a sentence and eliminate.

RAPID GRID: zabti measures; dahsala averages; batai shares; kankut appraises; nasaq estimates. Zat ranks; sawar obliges. Dagh brands; chehra describes. Jama claims; hasil receives.

PART XVII — Building a high-scoring answer from a state-capacity question

Questions on Akbar's administration reward a clear scale of analysis. Start with a thesis that defines the state as **ruler-centred systematisation**, not as a modern bureaucracy. A strong opening can say: "Akbar increased imperial capacity by joining differentiated offices, a graded service elite, verifiable military claims and more legible fiscal assessment; the same system remained personal, uneven and mediated by local power." This sentence already creates the answer's argumentative map.

Then select evidence by function. For the central-government paragraph, use Bairam Khan and the curtailed wakil to establish why unchecked ministerial concentration was avoided. Add the diwan and mir bakhshi to show fiscal and personnel/military differentiation, plus the mir saman if material supply or household capacity is relevant. Do not pile up offices without explaining that distinct records and appointment streams gave the emperor more than one view of resources. For a provincial paragraph, use the twelve subas of 1580, the subadar alongside diwan/bakhshi/sadr-qazi, and then immediately qualify the diagram through distance and local power.

For mansabdari, move in an explicit chain: **rank -> salary/assignment -> service -> verification -> dependence/limit**. Name composite recruitment to establish integration; use the late 1595-96 zat-sawar distinction to establish refinement; use dagh/chehra to establish verification; use transfer and jama-hasil tension to qualify control. This sequence demonstrates why mansabdari was simultaneously social hierarchy, payment mechanism and military management. It also prevents a generic answer that merely defines "rank."

For revenue, use a different chain: **measure/estimate -> rate/average -> cash claim -> record -> realisation -> local variation**. Mention the reform team rather than Todar Mal alone; distinguish zabti from dahsala; explain the ten-year produce-price average and theoretical one-third cash conversion; then bring in batai, kankut and nasaq to

refute universal application. Finish with jama versus hasil and zamindar mediation to show that assessment is not equal to collection. This is more analytical than a definition list.

Source criticism should serve the argument rather than form an isolated appendix. For example, after citing the Ain-i-Akbari for categories or compiled order, write that Abu'l Fazl's patronage and idealising project require a norm-practice qualification. Bring in Badauni only where a contrasting courtly/religious perception matters, and name farmans, records, coins or inscriptions as sources for particular claims rather than universal lived experience. Such source discipline converts a textbook point into historiography.

Finally, make the conclusion answer the directive with a graded verdict. "The state was centralising" is incomplete. Better: "Its records, rank and provincial replication materially enlarged the emperor's reach, yet their efficacy depended on intermediaries, actual rather than paper contingents, local methods and personal supervision." This preserves achievement and limitation in one defensible conclusion. It is especially valuable in a 20-marker because it prevents a false choice between perfect centralisation and administrative failure.

Answer demand	Best evidence combination	Qualification that adds marks
Checks and balances	Bairam wakil + diwan/mir bakhshi + provincial pairing	no constitutional separation
Mansabdari	composite elite + zat/sawar + dagh/chehra	patronage, paper-actual gap
Dahsala	reform team + jarib + ten-year averages	not uniform/permanent; cash risk
State capacity	Ain + offices + records + subas	norms versus practice, intermediaries

WHY THIS METHOD EARNS MARKS: It fulfils the directive, gives named evidence, explains a mechanism, qualifies claims and finishes with a reasoned verdict—rather than using “centralisation” as an unsupported label.

PART XVIII — From imperial rule to local outcome: an implementation audit

A complete account of Akbar's government must distinguish an institution's intended design from its operating conditions. Design begins at the court: the emperor appoints and ranks officials; offices receive differentiated fields; manuals and record systems make resources visible; provincial counterparts reproduce a pattern. Operation begins where a decision meets distance, climate, crop, local knowledge, military pressure and the interests of men who collect, record or command. This distinction is central to every limitation in the topic.

Take provincial administration. A centrally appointed subadar, diwan and bakhshi embody a deliberate refusal to put all civil, fiscal and military leverage in one pair of hands. But appointments travel through patronage, a provincial governor might have campaign experience and local connections, and reporting depended on the willingness and capacity of subordinates. Formal parallelism did not guarantee equal leverage. The right claim is that the arrangement created channels for supervision and rivalry, not that it produced automatic compliance.

Take fiscal assessment. The jarib, crop-rate practice and ten-year averaging represent a serious attempt to make fields and claims legible. Yet land could be difficult to measure, productivity could vary, prices could move, and cultivation could be interrupted. The persistence of batai, kankut and nasaq gives concrete form to that problem. Alternatives were not necessarily evidence that officials ignored policy; they could be rational responses to information and terrain. Nevertheless, alternative methods could also leave more scope for negotiation, discretionary estimation and unequal pressure.

Take military service. Dagh and chehra show that the court knew a number in a mansab record was not a sufficient indicator of fighting capacity. Branding and descriptive rolls sought a test. The very need for a test tells the historian that nominal and actual strength could diverge. Inspection cannot be assessed simply as “success” or “failure”: it raises the cost of deception, produces records for punishment or correction, but also creates compliance costs, official opportunities for harassment and incentives to evade.

Take village society. Pargana staff, patwaris, chaudhurs, muqaddams and zamindars provided the state with information and routes of collection. Their inclusion made imperial reach possible; their position also made direct uniform state contact unlikely. A cultivator's encounter with revenue may have been shaped by the local intermediary, harvest and market as much as by a norm in the Ain. One must not write either that Mughal administration bypassed

villages or that villages sat outside the imperial system.

This implementation audit also controls language. Prefer “**sought to**,” “**enabled**,” “**could check**,” “**is associated with**,” and “**was limited by**” where sources describe a rule or institutional intention. Reserve “**universally ensured**,” “**completely eliminated**,” “**everywhere applied**,” and “**automatically produced**” for claims supported by evidence that this topic does not provide. Such verbs are a practical source-critical safeguard.

Designed instrument	Intended administrative gain	Operating qualification
differentiated offices	cross-checking and specialised knowledge	ruler still depends on personnel and reports
jagir transfer	reduce stable territorial roots	short-term extraction incentive
dagh/chehra	test service claim	resistance, cost and evasion
zabti/dahsala	predictable assessment	uneven coverage, cash/price risk
local record chain	make demand legible	intermediaries mediate and negotiate

Implementation verdict. The Mughal state under Akbar was powerful because it built administrative techniques for precisely these operating problems. Its limitations do not reduce it to a fiction; they identify the social and material conditions under which early modern centralisation worked.

A layered case study: what one revenue order had to pass through

Imagine the logic—not a fabricated individual case—of a revenue demand moving from imperial calculation to local result. At the centre, fiscal policy requires a revenue estimate intelligible enough to support salaries, household expenditure and campaign. The diwan's world is therefore one of totals, assignments, expenditures and comparison of returns. In an assessed zone, measurement, crop knowledge and a rate schedule make a **jama** possible. The use of a ten-year produce-price average in dahsala seeks to avoid letting one exceptional year dominate the calculation. This is a genuine gain in fiscal intelligibility.

At the provincial level, that claim has to become a monitored demand. A provincial diwan and subordinate record staff make the assessment part of a chain of accounts. The subadar's wider political-military authority gives the state coercive presence, but the separation of offices means that fiscal language does not originate only in the governor's command. If a jagir supports a mansabdar, the chain also connects the apparent value of an assignment to the wider salary and service hierarchy. A high figure on paper may support a high claim; it remains necessary to ask what can actually be received.

At pargana and village levels, the requirement meets the archive of local knowledge: field histories, crop conditions, people who know boundaries, prior payments and social obligations. Qanungos, patwaris, amils, chaudhurs, muqaddams and zamindars do not all perform identical tasks, but together they make the fiscal process socially embedded. Their involvement can prevent a distant office from working blindly; it can also make collection dependent on unequal local power. A state whose record needs intermediaries cannot be reduced to direct bureaucracy.

At realisation, harvest, price, transport and bargaining determine whether the scheduled **jama** becomes **hasil**. Crop sharing through batai may be more workable in one setting; kankut or nasaq may lower the cost of a full fresh measurement elsewhere. A remission in crop failure can be fiscally rational because abandoned cultivation harms future returns. But fiscal rationality does not settle the distributive question for cultivators. The burden can still be sharpened by cesses, monetisation pressure, local exactions or coercion. This is why a well-written conclusion says that predictability may coexist with extraction.

At the point of feedback, reports and accounts return upward. They can reveal a shortfall, justify adjustment, expose an official or leave a problem concealed. The same feedback logic applies to mansab: a rank, a listed salary and a supposed contingent acquire value only when record, muster and inspection relate them to actual people and resources. Thus revenue administration, nobility management and military control are connected by a broader state practice: the court repeatedly turns social resources into ranked, recorded and reviewable claims.

This layered case study supplies a compact answer to the question, “How did Akbar's state reach the countryside?” It did so neither by direct contact with every peasant nor by surrendering authority to local society. It created procedures and offices that worked through intermediaries, then attempted to supervise the result. The quality of that supervision varied; its aspiration and institutional traces are nevertheless historically significant.

A historian's checklist before accepting a strong claim

When a source gives a precise total, first identify the unit. Is it a mansab rank, an assessed jama, a realised hasil, a suba count, a category of land, or a description of horses? Numbers travel badly across categories. A high mansab is not automatically an actual number of fighting men after zat-sawar; a jama is not a cash balance after hasil; a territorial hierarchy does not establish a faujdar's identical jurisdiction everywhere. Defining the unit is often the difference between using evidence and merely displaying it.

Next identify the temporal layer. The 1567 numerical hierarchy, 1573-74 dagh, 1580 dahsala/subas and 1595-96 zat-sawar do not describe one simultaneous institutional moment. A source compiled late in the reign may give a mature pattern, while a question may ask about an early practice. This is why an answer should use dates as arguments: "The later distinction clarifies an earlier ambiguity" is stronger than "the system was always dual-ranked."

Then identify the geographic layer. A rate or method in an identified zabt zone cannot automatically become an all-India rule. Claims about Lahore-to-Allahabad, Malwa and Gujarat need the companion observation that methods varied elsewhere. The map of a state is not the map of equal administrative depth. Forested, hilly, frontier and regionally distinct areas can preserve different relations of measurement, crop sharing, estimate and local authority.

Finally identify the voice. Abu'l Fazl's account can be especially informative about imperial categories and justifications because it participates in the court's administrative-literary project. It must be read against the possibility of idealisation. Badauni's criticism can reveal resistance or disagreement, but it must be read against his own position. A farman establishes a command, not necessarily the final local result; a coin indicates a circulation or claim, not the entire agrarian structure. Triangulation is not an optional "source criticism" sentence appended at the end—it is how claims about capacity remain proportionate to evidence.

Use this final test before writing: Have I named the institution? Have I stated its mechanism? Have I dated it correctly? Have I specified the scale? Have I separated norm from practice? Have I admitted one concrete limit? If all six answers are yes, the response is likely both fact-safe and analytical.

Synthesis: why the pieces belong in one topic

Mansabdari and dahsala are often revised as separate chapters because one appears military and the other agrarian. Akbar's state made them interdependent. A graded service elite needed dependable remuneration; remuneration required a fiscal claim; a fiscal claim depended on records and local mediation; and the capacity to use a service elite in war depended on knowing whether paper cavalry existed in fact. Diwan, mir bakhshi, provincial officers, record personnel and household supply should therefore be seen as connecting nodes rather than isolated facts.

This synthesis also explains the central position of the emperor. He was not merely the ceremonial summit above self-running departments. Appointment, promotion, transfer, grant, audit and dispute settlement acquired force through sovereign patronage. That personal centre could coordinate a diverse empire, but it meant the system relied on supervision, information and court politics rather than an impersonal constitutional routine. "Centralisation" in this context is a process of making resources reportable to the centre, not the disappearance of regional variation.

The final conceptual formula is therefore: **imperial authority + differentiated offices

- ranked elite + revenue information + verification + local mediation = substantial but uneven early modern state capacity.** Every term after the plus sign also carries a limit: officers can compete, rank can be nominal, assessments can exceed receipts, inspections can be evaded, and intermediaries can bargain. A conclusion that preserves this double movement is more accurate than a celebration of administrative "perfection."

PART XIV — Practice and examiner feedback

Learning MCQ loop — 20 questions (A -> B -> C -> D repeated five times)

Q1. Which statement best captures the relationship between zabti and dahsala?

A. Zabti is measurement-based assessment; dahsala uses ten-year produce and price averages in assessment. B. Dahsala was a permanent ten-year settlement. C. Zabti was a crop-sharing method. D. Both terms mean a hereditary revenue grant. **Answer: A — Zabti is measurement-based assessment; dahsala uses ten-year produce and price averages in assessment.** **Explanation:** The discriminator is that zabti names a measurement-based mode while dahsala names an averaging method. The closest distractor makes dahsala a fixed-tenure settlement, confusing data window with settlement duration.

Q2. The principal political lesson Akbar drew from Bairam Khan's early regency was to

A. make the diwan a hereditary office. B. prevent the wakil from becoming a permanently over-mighty centre of effective power. C. abolish all provincial governors. D. separate religion from all administration. **Answer: B — prevent the wakil from becoming a permanently over-mighty centre of effective power.** **Explanation:** The answer follows the reduced effective power of the wakil after Bairam Khan. The plausible but wrong fiscal alternative mistakes a regency lesson for a rule about the diwan.

Q3. Which officer is most closely connected with mansab recommendations, presentation and muster records?

A. Diwan B. Mir saman C. Mir bakhshi D. Sadr-us-sudur **Answer: C — Mir bakhshi** **Explanation:** Mir bakhshi is the rank-and-muster node. Diwan is the closest distractor because finance could overlap with payment, but he was not the primary officer for presentation and military record.

Q4. In Akbar's provincial design, the strongest evidence of a ruler-centred check is that

A. the subadar owned all land in the suba. B. each suba was a federal province. C. village institutions were abolished. D. provincial officers were centrally appointed and their functions were differentiated. **Answer: D — provincial officers were centrally appointed and their functions were differentiated.** **Explanation:** Central appointment plus separate functions is the check. A federal-province analogy fails because authority derived from imperial appointment, not constitutional autonomy.

Q5. The correct ascending sequence of territorial units is

A. pargana -> sarkar -> suba. B. suba -> sarkar -> pargana. C. sarkar -> pargana -> suba. D. village -> suba -> pargana. **Answer: A — pargana -> sarkar -> suba.** **Explanation:** Pargana is below sarkar and suba is larger. The closest wrong choice reverses pargana and sarkar while keeping suba at the top.

Q6. A jagir in the mansabdari context was primarily

A. a grant of absolute ownership in all village land. B. an assignment of state revenue used to meet remuneration. C. a hereditary sovereign province. D. a village panchayat treasury. **Answer: B — an assignment of state revenue used to meet remuneration.** **Explanation:** A revenue assignment is the key discriminator. The ownership distractor is tempting because revenue rights are substantial, but they are not private title.

Q7. The late distinction between zat and sawar separated

A. religious grant from judicial office. B. cash revenue from crop share. C. personal rank/status from cavalry obligation. D. a suba from a sarkar. **Answer: C — personal rank/status from cavalry obligation.** **Explanation:** Zat relates to personal status/pay and sawar to cavalry obligation. The cash/crop option is a revenue-method distinction, not a mansab distinction.

Q8. Which provenance chain for dagh and chehra is safest?

A. Akbar invented both without precedent. B. Sher Shah abolished them before Akbar. C. They were a British innovation. D. Alauddin Khalji introduced/used them; Sher Shah revived/adapted; Akbar systematised them in a Mughal framework. **Answer: D — Alauddin Khalji introduced/used them; Sher Shah revived/adapted; Akbar systematised them in a Mughal framework.** **Explanation:** Continuity through Alauddin, Sher Shah and Akbar is the required correction. The closest distractor erases precedent by assigning invention solely to Akbar.

Q9. The central purpose of horse branding and descriptive rolls was to

A. test claimed cavalry resources against actual horses and personnel. B. convert jagirs into property titles. C. fix village boundaries permanently. D. replace all cash payments with grain. **Answer: A — test claimed cavalry resources against actual horses and personnel.** **Explanation:** Dagh and chehra target fictitious musters and substitution. The jagir distractor imports a property issue unrelated to verification.

Q10. Which formulation best describes the imperial army under Akbar?

A. A fully national conscript army under one payroll. B. A cavalry-centred mix of mansabdar contingents, ahadis and other arms, not a modern uniform standing army. C. Only Rajput cavalry with no artillery. D. A force independent of mansab ranks. **Answer: B — A cavalry-centred mix of mansabdar contingents, ahadis and other arms, not a modern uniform standing army.** **Explanation:** The mixed composition and centrality of cavalry are the key. The modern national-army option fails because service and contingents were mediated through mansabdars.

Q11. Dahsala's ten years refer to

A. a guaranteed ten-year tenure for each cultivator. B. a ten-year ban on crop sharing. C. the averaging of produce and prices used in assessment. D. the tenure of every jagir. **Answer: C — the averaging of produce and prices used in assessment.** **Explanation:** The word 'dahsala' points to the averaging calculation. The plausible wrong option converts a fiscal technique into permanent land tenure.

Q12. The jarib described in the revenue system principally served to

A. brand cavalry horses. B. record soldiers' features. C. divide crop shares at harvest. D. measure land for assessment, with standardising devices such as bamboo linked by iron rings. **Answer: D — measure land for assessment, with standardising devices such as bamboo linked by iron rings.** **Explanation:** Jarib is a measuring instrument. Horse branding and descriptive roll are deliberately close technical distractors from the military system.

Q13. Polaj, parati/parauti, chachar and banjar are best treated as

A. categories linked to cultivation and fallow history. B. a simple hierarchy of caste status. C. the four ranks of mansabdars. D. four kinds of judicial court. **Answer: A — categories linked to cultivation and fallow history.** **Explanation:** Cultivation frequency is the discriminator. Calling them a fertility-only ladder overstates what the labels convey.

Q14. Batai or ghalla-bakhshi is

A. a ten-year price average. B. crop sharing in a fixed proportion. C. measurement plus standing-crop appraisal. D. an estimate based chiefly on past payment. **Answer: B — crop sharing in a fixed proportion.** **Explanation:** Batai is the crop-share method. Kankut is the closest distractor because it concerns crop assessment, but it combines measurement and appraisal rather than direct division.

Q15. Kankut is most accurately described as

A. a permanent cash settlement. B. a religious grant. C. measurement combined with inspection or appraisal of the standing crop. D. the separation of zat and sawar. **Answer: C — measurement combined with inspection or appraisal of the standing crop.** **Explanation:** The method combines measurement with estimate. The cash-settlement option misreads all revenue methods as zabt.

Q16. Nasaq differed from a fresh detailed zabt exercise because it relied substantially on

A. horse branding records. B. only division of harvested crop. C. the emperor's personal rank. D. previous assessment/payment and estimate. **Answer: D — previous assessment/payment and estimate.** **Explanation:** Nasaq's estimated, previous-demand logic is decisive. Crop division is batai, the closest revenue-method distractor.

Q17. The safest statement on geographic reach is that

A. zabt/dahsala had identified zones such as Lahore to Allahabad, Malwa and Gujarat, while alternatives persisted elsewhere. B. dahsala covered every field in all of India. C. only Bengal used measurement. D. no revenue method operated outside Agra. **Answer: A — zabt/dahsala had identified zones such as Lahore to Allahabad, Malwa and Gujarat, while alternatives persisted elsewhere.** **Explanation:** The source-bound geographic zones and uneven reach are correct. The universal-zabt claim is the intended trap.

Q18. Jama and hasil should be distinguished because

A. jama is cavalry rank whereas hasil is horse branding. B. jama is assessed demand whereas hasil is realised receipt. C. jama is a village council whereas hasil is a suba. D. both are exact synonyms for jagir. **Answer: B — jama is assessed demand whereas hasil is realised receipt.** **Explanation:** Assessment versus realisation is the fiscal distinction. Treating the terms as synonyms hides the paper-versus-receipt gap.

Q19. A zamindar is best understood as

A. simply a transferable imperial revenue assignee. B. a modern registered property owner. C. a local claimant and intermediary with social and sometimes armed power. D. the same office as mir bakhshi. **Answer: C — a local claimant and intermediary with social and sometimes armed power.** **Explanation:** Local claims and mediation distinguish zamindar from jagirdar. The transferable-assignee option is the closest because it describes the latter, not the former.

Q20. The most defensible conclusion on Akbar's checks is that

A. the emperor was constitutionally powerless. B. the system had modern judicial review. C. each office was an autonomous branch of government. D. separate offices and reports restrained concentration, but final authority remained ruler-centred. **Answer: D — separate offices and reports restrained concentration, but final authority remained ruler-centred.** **Explanation:** The answer preserves both differentiation and monarchical primacy. Autonomous-branch language is a misleading modern analogy.

Broad practice — 44 questions (A -> B -> C -> D repeated eleven times)

Q1. After Bairam Khan, the wakil most accurately retained

A. prestige without the earlier monopoly of effective regency power. B. a hereditary right to appoint all diwans. C. control over every provincial treasury. D. an independent constitutional veto. **Answer: A — prestige without the earlier monopoly of effective regency power.** **Explanation:** The post-regency change curtailed effective concentration, not the office's existence. The veto option imports constitutional language alien to the arrangement.

Q2. A diwan's scrutiny of khalisa, jagir and inam chiefly shows responsibility for

A. horse branding at muster. B. fiscal accounts and the allocation of revenue claims. C. criminal policing in every village. D. the personal rank of all qazis. **Answer: B — fiscal accounts and the allocation of revenue claims.**

Explanation: Accounts and fiscal destinations lie in the diwan's field. Horse branding belongs to dagh, the deliberately nearby military distractor.

Q3. Why should mir bakhshi not be translated simply as 'defence minister'?

A. He had no connection with military personnel. B. He only maintained karkhanas. C. His rank, presentation, muster and record functions operated inside personal imperial authority. D. He was a village revenue officer. **Answer: C — His rank, presentation, muster and record functions operated inside personal imperial authority.**

Explanation: The issue is anachronistic equivalence, not absence of military work. Karkhanas belong to the mir saman's field.

Q4. The mir saman/khan-i-saman is most useful in an answer on

A. judicial independence from the emperor. B. ten-year revenue averaging. C. suba boundaries. D. household, workshops, stores and material imperial capacity. **Answer: D — household, workshops, stores and material imperial capacity.**

Explanation: Household logistics and karkhanas are the defining connection. Revenue averaging belongs to dahsala, not this office.

Q5. The cautious statement on sadr and qazi is that they

A. handled grant and judicial-religious functions within imperial political authority. B. formed a modern independent supreme court. C. were elected provincial representatives. D. replaced the diwan in fiscal audit. **Answer: A — handled grant and judicial-religious functions within imperial political authority.**

Explanation: The functions are real but institutionally dependent. The modern-court option mistakes judicial activity for constitutional autonomy.

Q6. Which provincial arrangement most directly limited a subadar's monopoly?

A. Giving the subadar permanent ownership of jagirs. B. A provincial diwan separately handling fiscal records and accounts. C. Abolishing reporting to the centre. D. Making every village a suba. **Answer: B — A provincial diwan separately handling fiscal records and accounts.**

Explanation: A distinct diwan created a parallel fiscal channel. Permanent ownership would intensify rather than restrain local concentration.

Q7. The 2021 hierarchy PYQ tests the fact that a pargana is

A. a rank above a mansab. B. a type of revenue grant. C. smaller than a sarkar and larger than no listed higher unit in the sequence. D. a unit above suba. **Answer: C — smaller than a sarkar and larger than no listed higher unit in the sequence.**

Explanation: Pargana is the first ascending unit in pargana-sarkar-suba. The rank and grant choices deliberately cross technical baskets.

Q8. A safe qualification about a faujdar is that

A. he had no relation to order or force. B. he was identical with a patwari. C. he always assessed dahsala averages. D. his coercive jurisdiction was not always exactly coterminous with one sarkar. **Answer: D — his coercive jurisdiction was not always exactly coterminous with one sarkar.**

Explanation: Variation in jurisdiction is the point. The patwari alternative confuses a local record role with a coercive office.

Q9. The qanungo is most plausibly placed in a discussion of

A. pargana-level local records and revenue knowledge. B. imperial household workshops. C. cavalry branding. D. the sovereign's daily darbar. **Answer: A — pargana-level local records and revenue knowledge.**

Explanation: Qanungo belongs to the record cluster supporting assessment. Branding is dagh, an intentionally technical but wrong alternative.

Q10. Which actor best represents village-level fiscal mediation?

A. A mir bakhshi presenting mansabdars. B. A muqaddam/patel working amid local records and custom. C. A provincial sadr issuing grants. D. A high-zat court noble only. **Answer: B — A muqaddam/patel working amid local records and custom.** **Explanation:** Muqaddam or patel reflects local mediation. The other options operate at court or provincial scale.

Q11. Khalisa revenues were distinguished because they were

A. the private landed property of every mansabdar. B. a synonym for madad-i-maash. C. reserved for the crown rather than assigned as a jagir. D. a cavalry category. **Answer: C — reserved for the crown rather than assigned as a jagir.** **Explanation:** Crown revenue is the discriminator. A jagir is an assignment, while a madad-i-maash/inam is a different grant form.

Q12. Madad-i-maash/inam is best placed under

A. the suba-sarkar territorial ladder. B. horse and soldier verification. C. the crop-share method. D. grant arrangements, distinct from routine jagir remuneration. **Answer: D — grant arrangements, distinct from routine jagir remuneration.** **Explanation:** The terms belong to grants. Crop share describes batai, which is a revenue-assessment method rather than a grant.

Q13. Why is a mansab more than a military quota?

A. It simultaneously expressed rank, remuneration and service obligation. B. It permanently transferred land title. C. It fixed a village's crop type. D. It was only a religious donation. **Answer: A — It simultaneously expressed rank, remuneration and service obligation.** **Explanation:** The three-part service relationship is essential. Land title is the standard jagir misconception, not the meaning of mansab.

Q14. A statement that all Akbar-era ranks followed one unchanging table is weak because

A. ranks began only after 1707. B. the system developed in stages and high ranks marked changing imperial elevation. C. no rank was ever linked to pay. D. mansab applied only to peasants. **Answer: B — the system developed in stages and high ranks marked changing imperial elevation.** **Explanation:** Development over the reign is the correction. The 1707 and peasant options contradict the system's basic setting.

Q15. Composite recruitment mattered because it

A. abolished every group identity immediately. B. made all offices hereditary. C. placed varied elite backgrounds within a common imperial hierarchy of service and favour. D. removed the emperor from appointments. **Answer: C — placed varied elite backgrounds within a common imperial hierarchy of service and favour.** **Explanation:** Integration is not social erasure. The hereditary option reverses the role of imperial appointment and transfer.

Q16. The late zat-sawar division made it possible to distinguish

A. a village from a pargana. B. a crop rate from a price average. C. a qazi from a sadr. D. courtly personal standing from the cavalry resource a holder owed. **Answer: D — courtly personal standing from the cavalry resource a holder owed.** **Explanation:** The distinction is within mansab. The revenue and territorial pairs are close-sounding but belong to different systems.

Q17. An assignment based on a high jama could disappoint a mansabdar because

A. actual hasil might fall short of assessed paper demand. B. jama was a horse-branding register. C. hasil was always a rank above zat. D. jagir automatically meant ownership. **Answer: A — actual hasil might fall short of assessed paper demand.** **Explanation:** Jama versus hasil is assessment versus receipt. The closest distractor repeats the ownership error that the distinction is meant to prevent.

Q18. Transfer of jagirs most directly served the centre by

A. making every assignment hereditary. B. keeping an assignee's position dependent on imperial reassignment. C. ending all local intermediaries. D. turning provinces into federations. **Answer: B — keeping an assignee's position dependent on imperial reassignment.** **Explanation:** Transfer can curb durable local roots. Hereditary and federal alternatives reverse the logic of imperial dependence.

Q19. Akbar's 1573-74 dagh measure is most directly connected to

A. classification of fallow land. B. the appointment of a qazi. C. inspection of horses claimed for service. D. a ten-year price average. **Answer: C — inspection of horses claimed for service.** **Explanation:** Dagh is horse branding. Fallow categories and price averaging are revenue concepts placed as technical traps.

Q20. Chehra was valuable because it

A. measured a field with bamboo rings. B. assigned crown revenue to khalisa. C. converted produce into cash rates. D. made soldiers individually describable for muster-related scrutiny. **Answer: D — made soldiers individually describable for muster-related scrutiny.** **Explanation:** Descriptive rolls make personnel more legible. The jarib and cash-rate choices belong to revenue assessment.

Q21. Ahadis help qualify a statement that the army consisted only of

A. mansabdar contingents, since centrally associated elements also existed. B. revenue clerks, because ahadis were accountants. C. village councils, because ahadis were panchayats. D. crop shares, because ahadis were batai. **Answer: A — mansabdar contingents, since centrally associated elements also existed.** **Explanation:** Ahadis are relevant to imperial military composition. The other choices deliberately replace military vocabulary with civil or fiscal vocabulary.

Q22. The cautious role of news writers is to show that

A. all reports were false by definition. B. information and reports supported central oversight without proving one uniform modern intelligence service. C. the diwan ceased fiscal work. D. every village was directly ruled by mir bakhshi. **Answer: B — information and reports supported central oversight without proving one uniform modern intelligence service.** **Explanation:** Reports indicate an oversight aspiration and practice. The modern-agency claim is the close anachronistic overstatement.

Q23. Why did central price schedules create a revenue problem?

A. They made all measurements unnecessary. B. They abolished currency. C. Court-centred prices could be delayed or ill suited to local conditions. D. They turned jagirs into titles. **Answer: C — Court-centred prices could be delayed or ill suited to local conditions.** **Explanation:** Regional variation and delay are the mechanism. The other options confuse price policy with land measurement or legal title.

Q24. A statement that revenue reform was 'peasant welfare only' is inadequate because

A. peasants never cultivated under Akbar. B. revenue had no relation to records. C. only religious grants funded the empire. D. predictable assessment also served imperial finance, control and military remuneration. **Answer: D — predictable assessment also served imperial finance, control and military remuneration.** **Explanation:** Fiscal extraction and capacity are central objectives. The welfare-only claim misses why the court needed assessment.

Q25. The iron-linked bamboo jarib is evidence for

A. an effort to reduce manipulation in measurement. B. a device for listing soldiers. C. a symbol of a permanent settlement. D. a method of crop sharing. **Answer: A — an effort to reduce manipulation in measurement.** **Explanation:** Anti-stretching standardisation is the point. Soldier listing is chehra, while crop share is batai.

Q26. Dastur is most safely invoked as

A. a rank above 5000. B. a crop-rate/rate-setting element in assessment practice. C. a village judicial body. D. a branded horse. **Answer: B — a crop-rate/rate-setting element in assessment practice.** **Explanation:** Dastur belongs to rate formation. The rank and horse choices test whether vocabulary has been put in the wrong basket.

Q27. The land categories are analytically useful because they

A. measure the number of cavalymen. B. name three provincial offices. C. track regular cultivation and lengths of fallow, not caste hierarchy. D. fix a cash salary. **Answer: C — track regular cultivation and lengths of fallow, not caste hierarchy.** **Explanation:** Cultivation history is the discriminating idea. Cavalry and salary relate to mansabdari rather than land-use categories.

Q28. Polaj should not be defined simply as

A. land regularly cultivated. B. a category used with other fallow labels. C. a revenue-relevant land-use description. D. the most fertile land in every context, because the categories concern cultivation frequency. **Answer: D — the most fertile land in every context, because the categories concern cultivation frequency.** **Explanation:** The exclusion is the fertility-only simplification. Regular cultivation is the safer description.

Q29. A collector using a fixed share of the harvested crop is closest to

A. batai or ghalla-bakhshi. B. nasaq. C. dahsala. D. chehra. **Answer: A — batai or ghalla-bakhshi.** **Explanation:** Crop division identifies batai. Nasaq relies on estimate from prior demand, while chehra records soldiers.

Q30. A field measured and then assessed through appraisal of standing crop illustrates

A. khalisa. B. kankut. C. sawar. D. inam. **Answer: B — kankut.** **Explanation:** Measurement plus estimate is the exact kankut discriminator. Khalisa and inam are fiscal destinations/grants, not assessment techniques.

Q31. An estimate based substantially on earlier demand rather than fresh full survey illustrates

A. zabti. B. dagh. C. nasaq. D. pargana. **Answer: C — nasaq.** **Explanation:** Nasaq uses earlier assessment/payment as an important base. Zabt foregrounds measurement, and dagh concerns horses.

Q32. Which formulation best states the geographic limit of zabt?

A. It was applied identically throughout all India. B. It operated only inside imperial karkhanas. C. It excluded Malwa and Gujarat by definition. D. It had identified core zones but did not erase alternative methods in difficult or varied regions. **Answer: D — It had identified core zones but did not erase alternative methods in difficult or varied regions.** **Explanation:** Uneven extension is the source-grounded conclusion. The all-India option is the standard universal-zabt trap.

Q33. Cash assessment should be interpreted as

A. a stimulus to monetisation and market linkage, qualified by regional unevenness. B. proof that all agrarian exchange became commercial. C. proof that grain arrangements vanished. D. a definition of village autonomy. **Answer: A — a stimulus to monetisation and market linkage, qualified by regional unevenness.** **Explanation:** The trend is real but not total. The complete-commercialisation option converts a tendency into an unsupported universal conclusion.

Q34. Why do historians separate jama from hasil?

A. It separates two types of cavalry. B. The distinction tests whether an assessed fiscal claim was actually realised. C. It separates two courts of law. D. It separates two kinds of horse brand. **Answer: B — The distinction tests whether an assessed fiscal claim was actually realised.** **Explanation:** The terms let an answer see fiscal shortfall. Military, court and branding alternatives misplace a fiscal distinction.

Q35. A zamindar's significance for state capacity lies partly in

A. his automatic right to a mansab. B. his identity as a central diwan. C. local mediation, claims and social/armed resources that could assist or constrain collection. D. his exemption from every revenue claim. **Answer: C — local mediation, claims and social/armed resources that could assist or constrain collection.** **Explanation:** Mediation makes zamindars both resource and limit. The diwan and automatic-mansab options collapse local and central roles.

Q36. The most precise iqta-jagir comparison begins by noting

A. both were identical private property titles. B. Akbar invented the first of them. C. neither had any fiscal connection. D. both linked revenue assignments to service while differing in context, audit, tenure and systematisation. **Answer: D — both linked revenue assignments to service while differing in context, audit, tenure and systematisation.** **Explanation:** Controlled similarity is correct. Identity and first-invention claims both discard historical differentiation.

Q37. Sher Shah's relevance to Akbar's revenue history is that

A. his precedents informed later refinement without making Akbar's system a mere copy. B. he created zat-sawar in 1595-96. C. he abolished measurement permanently. D. he wrote Ain-i-Akbari. **Answer: A — his precedents informed later refinement without making Akbar's system a mere copy.** **Explanation:** Precedent plus adaptation is the point. Zat-sawar and Ain belong to Akbar's later system and Abu'l Fazl's project.

Q38. Which is a structural limitation rather than a denial of Akbar's capacity?

A. The existence of any rank hierarchy. B. The gap between nominal contingents and actual musters. C. The use of all records. D. The division into subas. **Answer: B — The gap between nominal contingents and actual musters.** **Explanation:** Paper-versus-actual capacity qualifies inspection. The other options are core instruments of systematisation, not limits in themselves.

Q39. Ain-i-Akbari is strongest when used for

A. a complete modern census of every locality. B. an unmediated peasant diary. C. administrative categories, official norms and the imperial vision of order. D. an official UPSC answer key. **Answer: C — administrative categories, official norms and the imperial vision of order.** **Explanation:** Genre makes the Ain rich for official repertoire and weak for universal practice. The census claim is the closest over-reading.

Q40. Abu'l Fazl's praise most directly requires the historian to

A. discard every administrative category he reports. B. treat Badauni as automatically neutral. C. ignore farmans and records. D. separate imperial ideology from an automatic proof of implementation. **Answer: D — separate imperial ideology from an automatic proof of implementation.** **Explanation:** Patronage calls for qualification, not wholesale rejection. Badauni also has a positional lens and cannot be automatic correction.

Q41. Badauni is most responsibly used as

A. a situated, often hostile courtly voice that can illuminate dissent but needs criticism. B. a statistically complete fiscal survey. C. the author of the Ain-i-Akbari. D. a proof that all regulations failed. **Answer: A — a situated, often hostile courtly voice that can illuminate dissent but needs criticism.** **Explanation:** A hostile voice offers a different perspective, not a universal verdict. The authorship option confuses him with Abu'l Fazl.

Q42. Why are farmans, coins and records valuable alongside chronicles?

A. They eliminate all source bias. B. They can corroborate particular orders, transactions or claims through distinct evidentiary traces. C. They make local variation irrelevant. D. They prove every norm was universally enforced. **Answer: B — They can corroborate particular orders, transactions or claims through distinct evidentiary traces.** **Explanation:** Complementary genres can test specific claims, but none removes context or proves universal implementation.

Q43. Which modern comparison stays within a safe boundary?

A. Calling jagir a digital property title. B. Calling suba a constitutionally sovereign state. C. Using an audit analogy for verification while denying equivalence to modern democratic accountability. D. Calling mansab an open competitive civil-service exam. **Answer: C — Using an audit analogy for verification while denying equivalence to modern democratic accountability.** **Explanation:** A narrow functional analogy is allowed. The other choices import legal and political equivalences that the evidence does not support.

Q44. The strongest overall verdict on Akbar's state capacity is that it

A. was either perfectly centralised or wholly fictitious. B. abolished local power completely. C. operated without coercion or market risk. D. systematised rank, records, revenue and oversight while remaining personal, hierarchical and uneven in reach. **Answer: D — systematised rank, records, revenue and oversight while remaining personal, hierarchical and uneven in reach.** **Explanation:** The balanced verdict holds achievement and limit together. The perfect-or-fictitious choice creates the false binary the topic rejects.

Remedial MCQs — 16 questions (A -> B -> C -> D repeated four times)

Q1. A learner says, “Dahsala and zabt are identical.” What is the best correction?

A. Zabt is measurement-based assessment; dahsala is an averaging device used in assessment. B. Both are names for crop sharing. C. Dahsala is only a horse-inspection measure. D. Zabt means a permanent ten-year tenure. **Answer: A — Zabt is measurement-based assessment; dahsala is an averaging device used in assessment.** **Explanation:** The two terms are connected but not identical. The nearest error is treating ten-year averaging as an immutable settlement.

Q2. What does the 'ten' in dahsala most safely indicate?

A. A ten-year transfer ban on jagirdars. B. A ten-year data average of produce and prices. C. Ten fixed annual crop shares. D. Ten ranks within mansabdari. **Answer: B — A ten-year data average of produce and prices.** **Explanation:** The correct choice identifies the calculation. The transfer-ban distractor mistakes a fiscal data period for personnel policy.

Q3. Which pairing is correct?

A. Zat—crop share; sawar—cash rate. B. Zat—provincial governor; sawar—diwan. C. Zat—personal status/pay; sawar—cavalry obligation. D. Zat—horse brand; sawar—soldier roll. **Answer: C — Zat—personal status/pay; sawar—cavalry obligation.** **Explanation:** The pair separates two dimensions of mansab. Horse brand and soldier roll describe dagh and chehra, not zat and sawar.

Q4. Why is “jagir equals land ownership” unsound?

A. Jagirs were village panchayats. B. Jagirs were always cash salaries only. C. Jagirs were judicial courts. D. It mistakes a state revenue assignment for private title. **Answer: D — It mistakes a state revenue assignment for private title.** **Explanation:** The revenue-right/title distinction is decisive. Cash salary is a related payment mode, but it does not define jagir.

Q5. Which contrast best distinguishes jagirdar from zamindar?

A. Jagirdar was generally a transferable imperial assignee; zamindar held local claims and mediation power. B. Jagirdar was always a peasant; zamindar always an emperor. C. They were identical labels for mir bakhshi. D. Zamindar was a rank above 7000. **Answer: A — Jagirdar was generally a transferable imperial assignee; zamindar held local claims and mediation power.** **Explanation:** The distinction is relationship to revenue and locality. Both had power, but not the same institutional position.

Q6. Which ascending order prevents the common hierarchy error?

A. suba -> pargana -> sarkar. B. pargana -> sarkar -> suba. C. sarkar -> suba -> pargana. D. village -> suba -> sarkar.

Answer: B — pargana -> sarkar -> suba. **Explanation:** Pargana, sarkar and suba are the progressively larger units. The closest error moves pargana above sarkar.

Q7. Which statement prevents a diwan/mir bakhshi mix-up?

A. Diwan branded horses and mir bakhshi measured fields. B. Diwan was only a village clerk. C. Diwan handled fiscal accounts; mir bakhshi handled rank, presentation and muster records. D. Mir bakhshi was a hereditary zamindar.

Answer: C — Diwan handled fiscal accounts; mir bakhshi handled rank, presentation and muster records. **Explanation:** Functional specialisation is the discriminator. Branding and measuring are techniques, not the core division of these offices.

Q8. Why is 'Todar Mal alone created dahsala' weak?

A. Todar Mal never worked in revenue. B. Only Bairam Khan set rates. C. No records were used in the system. D. Revenue reform involved Muzaffar Khan Turbati, Todar Mal and Shah Mansur, alongside evolving experiments.

Answer: D — Revenue reform involved Muzaffar Khan Turbati, Todar Mal and Shah Mansur, alongside evolving experiments. **Explanation:** The correction is collective institutional work, not erasing Todar Mal. The Bairam option wrongly turns a regent into fiscal architect.

Q9. What refutes a universal-zabt claim?

A. Batai, kankut and nasaq remained alternatives where terrain, crop or records made fresh measurement unsuitable. B. All alternatives were religious grants. C. Zabt applied only to military camps. D. Dahsala prohibited local estimation.

Answer: A — Batai, kankut and nasaq remained alternatives where terrain, crop or records made fresh measurement unsuitable. **Explanation:** Multiple methods reveal uneven capacity. The closest wrong option imagines dahsala legally barred estimation.

Q10. Which sequence correctly maps the cultivation categories from more regular to long uncultivated use?

A. banjar -> chachar -> polaj -> parati. B. polaj -> parati/parauti -> chachar -> banjar. C. polaj -> chachar -> parati -> banjar. D. parati -> polaj -> banjar -> chachar. **Answer: B — polaj -> parati/parauti -> chachar -> banjar.**

Explanation: The discriminator is cultivation/fallow history. The close distractor swaps parati and chachar, confusing shorter and longer fallow.

Q11. Which trio is correctly matched?

A. Batai—horse brand; kankut—soldier roll; nasaq—jagir. B. Batai—ten-year average; kankut—cash title; nasaq—suba. C. Batai—crop share; kankut—measurement plus estimate; nasaq—previous-demand estimate. D. Batai—provincial check; kankut—rank; nasaq—grant. **Answer: C — Batai—crop share; kankut—measurement plus estimate; nasaq—previous-demand estimate.**

Explanation: All three are revenue methods with distinct techniques. The second option mixes revenue terms with military and territorial vocabulary.

Q12. Which statement preserves the dagh/chehra lineage?

A. Akbar invented both without precedent. B. The controls first appeared after Aurangzeb. C. Sher Shah replaced them with land categories. D. Alauddin used the controls, Sher Shah revived/adapted them, and Akbar systematised them in Mughal practice. **Answer: D — Alauddin used the controls, Sher Shah revived/adapted them, and Akbar systematised them in Mughal practice.** **Explanation:** Continuity with adaptation is the key. The invention option removes the Sultanate/Sur background.

Q13. Which analogy is acceptable only with an explicit boundary?

A. A payroll audit can clarify verification, but mansabdari was not a modern merit civil service. B. A suba was exactly a federal state. C. A jagir was exactly a digital property title. D. A qazi was an elected constitutional judge. **Answer: A — A payroll audit can clarify verification, but mansabdari was not a modern merit civil service.** **Explanation:** The limited functional analogy is valid; the other three project modern legal-political categories into a ruler-centred empire.

Q14. What does 'ruler-centred checks' mean?

A. Courts could depose the emperor through judicial review. B. Offices checked concentration through differentiated roles while the emperor retained appointment and final authority. C. The diwan was elected by villages. D. Subas had constitutionally guaranteed autonomy. **Answer: B — Offices checked concentration through differentiated roles while the emperor retained appointment and final authority.** **Explanation:** The phrase combines differentiation with monarchical primacy. Judicial review and elected office are modern imports.

Q15. Which statement best handles cash in the revenue system?

A. Every peasant everywhere paid only coin. B. Cash demand abolished local intermediaries. C. Cash assessment encouraged monetisation, but regional variation and kind arrangements qualify claims of complete commercialisation. D. Currency had no relation to markets. **Answer: C — Cash assessment encouraged monetisation, but regional variation and kind arrangements qualify claims of complete commercialisation.** **Explanation:** The answer holds trend and limitation together. The all-coin option turns an uneven fiscal tendency into a universal fact.

Q16. Why is Ain-i-Akbari not a modern census?

A. It contains no administrative information. B. It was written by Badauni as a hostile memoir. C. It is an official answer key. D. It records administrative ideals and compiled figures within an imperial project, requiring norm-versus-practice caution. **Answer: D — It records administrative ideals and compiled figures within an imperial project, requiring norm-versus-practice caution.** **Explanation:** Its value is real but bounded by genre and patronage. The Badauni option confuses contrasting source voices.

Examiner-grade solved Mains practice — 10 answers

Mains 1. [10 marks | 150 words] Explain the nature of checks and balances in Akbar's central administration.

Directive alignment: Explain the mechanism, not a modern constitutional doctrine.

Introduction. Akbar differentiated offices to prevent concentration of effective power, but the arrangement remained a personal monarchy in which appointment and final arbitration lay with the emperor.

Claim—evidence—analysis. The Bairam Khan regency supplied the key political lesson: after a powerful *wakil* had overshadowed the young ruler, the office retained prestige but was reduced in effective power. This prevented a permanent all-powerful wazir. Fiscal and military functions were then differentiated. The **diwan** scrutinised income, expenditure, khalisa, jagir and inam accounts, while the **mir bakhshi** dealt with mansab presentation, muster-related records and personnel. Their different information streams made unilateral capture harder. The **mir saman** managed household/karkhana resources, and sadr-qazi functions covered grants and justice, adding specialised rather than undifferentiated authority.

Qualification. These were not autonomous ministries, an elected cabinet or judicial review. Overlap, patronage and imperial intervention remained normal; expertise amplified the sovereign rather than limiting him constitutionally.

Conclusion. Akbar's checks were therefore administrative and ruler-centred: they disciplined office-holders and improved information while preserving personal monarchy.

Why this earns marks: It defines the limited sense of “checks,” uses Bairam Khan plus named offices as evidence, explains their mechanism, and explicitly rejects anachronism.

Mains 2. [15 marks | 200 words] Discuss the central and provincial government under Akbar. How far did its structure restrain provincial autonomy?

Directive alignment: Cover both levels and assess—not merely list—the restraint.

Introduction. Akbar combined central specialisation with provincial replication, seeking reliable revenue, service and information across an expanding empire.

Central design. The emperor remained the source of appointment, justice, military command and patronage. The diwan's accounts and the mir bakhshi's mansab/muster records separated fiscal from personnel-military information; the mir saman's household-karkhana charge made material supply visible; sadr-qazi functions connected grants and adjudication. The reduced post-Bairam *wakil* illustrates deliberate avoidance of one over-mighty coordinator.

Provincial design. In **1580**, the twelve-subas arrangement placed a **subadar** beside a provincial diwan, bakhshi, sadr-qazi and reporting personnel. The same principle operated below: suba -> sarkar -> pargana -> village. Amils, qanungos, treasurers and clerks supplied fiscal records; faujdars served coercive/order functions but their jurisdiction was not mechanically coterminous with every sarkar.

Assessment. Central appointment, differentiated functions and cross-reporting restrained a governor from monopolising revenue and force. Yet distance, campaign conditions, local alliances and the subadar's practical strength could weaken paper checks. Village and zamindari intermediaries also mediated reach.

Conclusion. The structure limited provincial autonomy more effectively than a single governor-centred chain, but it did so by imperial supervision, not federal or constitutional decentralisation.

Why this earns marks: It joins the two scales, dates the twelve-subas reform, names institutions and produces a qualified judgment about real rather than diagrammatic control.

Mains 3. [15 marks | 200 words] Examine mansabdari as both an elite-integration device and a military organisation.

Directive alignment: Treat both functions as mutually connected, not two separate lists.

Introduction. Mansabdari was a graded imperial service hierarchy in which a mansab fixed relative status, remuneration and service expectation; its strength was to make political incorporation and military obligation speak the same language.

Elite integration. Ranks beginning at 10 and reaching high grades such as 5000 (with exceptional 7000 ranks under Akbar) ordered a composite elite of Turanis, Iranis, Indian Muslims, Rajputs, Afghans and other entrants. Promotion, demotion, court honour, cash and jagir remuneration connected privilege to the emperor. This reduced the need to treat each aristocratic group as an autonomous territorial power, while family advantage and hierarchy remained.

Military organisation. A mansab was not only ceremonial. The later **zat-sawar** distinction (1595-96) separated personal status/pay from cavalry obligation, and the mir bakhshi's presentation and muster records tied rank to personnel. Dagh and chehra helped test horses and men against paper claims. Jagir assignments could finance service without converting the assignee into landowner.

Qualification. Actual contingents could fall short, inspections invited resistance or harassment, and jagir transfer encouraged dependence while creating short-term incentives. The system was neither hereditary feudalism nor a modern merit service.

Conclusion. Mansabdari integrated elites precisely because its honour, pay and military claims were interlocked under imperial review.

Why this earns marks: It answers both halves through one causal mechanism and anchors analysis in composite recruitment, 1595-96, dagh/chehra and jagir qualification.

Mains 4. [10 marks | 150 words] Explain the significance and limits of the zat-sawar distinction and verification devices under Akbar.

Directive alignment: Explain late rank refinement and assess verification, not merely define terms.

Introduction. The dual rank emerged in Akbar's fortieth regnal year, **1595-96**, showing that mansabdari evolved through clarification rather than beginning as a finished blueprint.

Significance. **Zat** denoted personal rank, courtly status and related pay; **sawar** identified cavalry obligation. Separating them made it easier to express a noble's precedence without assuming that personal eminence exactly equalled contingent size. The mir bakhshi's presentation and muster role linked the formula to record-making.

Verification. Dag (horse branding) and chehra (descriptive rolls) sought to expose fictitious horses, substituted mounts and nominal soldiers. Their line of provenance matters: Alauddin Khalji used such controls, Sher Shah revived/adapted them, and Akbar systematised them in the Mughal framework; Akbar's dag measure is placed in 1573-74.

Limits. Inspection was costly, nobles resisted intrusive checking, officials could harass, and a paper rank never guaranteed a full actual contingent. Technical "class" labels should not replace the basic distinction.

Conclusion. Together they sharpened imperial knowledge of service, but supplied partial control rather than a modern audited army.

Why this earns marks: It gets chronology and provenance right, connects terminology to institutional purpose, and names operational limits.

Mains 5. [15 marks | 200 words] Analyse the relationship between mansab, jagir and imperial dependence under Akbar.

Directive alignment: Explain a relationship and its tension; do not reduce jagir to ownership.

Introduction. A mansab set rank, remuneration and obligation; a jagir was often the revenue assignment through which the state met that remuneration. The connection bound service to imperial fiscal resources.

Mechanism. A graded mansab established a noble's salary claim and expected service. Cash payment was possible, but a jagir commonly assigned the right to collect specified state revenue. The diwan's scrutiny of khalisa, jagir and inam accounts and the language of **jama** versus **hasil** matter because a nominal assessment was not identical with actual receipt. Thus the assignment was calculated fiscal support, not a free-standing landed estate.

Dependence. Appointment, transfer, promotion, demotion and reassignment kept the mansabdar dependent on imperial favour and curtailed stable territorial roots. The contrast with a **zamindar** is essential: a jagirdar was generally a transferable assignee; a zamindar had local claims, mediation capacity and social/armed power.

Tension. Transfers could inhibit provincial independence yet make quick extraction attractive, especially if jama exceeded hasil. These are structural seeds later magnified in seventeenth-century pressure; they should not be inflated into an Akbar-era collapse.

Conclusion. Mansab-jagir linkage was an ingenious salary-and-control arrangement whose very flexibility produced a recurrent tension between central dependence and local extraction.

Why this earns marks: It distinguishes ownership from assignment, uses jama/hasil and jagirdar/zamindar precisely, then projects later consequences only with a time boundary.

Mains 6. [20 marks | 250 words] Explain the working of the dahsala system. Was it a uniform and permanent settlement?

Directive alignment: Explain process, then test two false assumptions—uniformity and permanence.

Introduction. Dahsala, implemented in **1580**, was a fiscal technique that used a ten-year average of produce and prices to make assessment more predictable; it was neither synonymous with every zabt operation nor a permanent ten-year settlement.

Working. Akbar's revenue experiments followed Sur precedents but found central price schedules too blunt for local variation. The team of **Muzaffar Khan Turbati**, **Todar Mal** and **Shah Mansur** developed more usable local productivity/price circles. Under measurement-based **zabti**, fields could be measured with a jarib described as

bamboo linked by iron rings. Dastur/crop-rate machinery combined area, yield and price knowledge. Dahsala averaged a decade's produce and prices; the theoretical state share was one-third of average produce, converted into cash. It gave both official and payer a more intelligible claim, while serving military and household finance.

Why not permanent. "Ten" identifies the data series, not a fixed decade-long tenure or unalterable demand. Crop failure, price conditions and later revision make a permanent- settlement analogy false. Remission and, where available, assistance could support cultivation, but they did not abolish pressure, cesses, transport costs or coercive collection.

Why not uniform. Zabti/dahsala is safely associated with zones from Lahore to Allahabad and with Malwa and Gujarat; it should not be made pan-Indian. Batai/ghalla-bakhshi, kankut and nasaq persisted where crop, terrain, staff and records made other methods more practical. Bengal, Sindh, Kashmir and difficult tracts require this capacity qualification.

Conclusion. Dahsala was sophisticated fiscal information technology—measurement, averaging, price conversion and record—not a universal, permanent or peasant-welfare-only settlement.

Why this earns marks: It gives a full mechanism, names the reform team and instrument, distinguishes terms, and directly disposes of both misconceptions with geographic evidence.

Mains 7. [20 marks | 250 words] Compare Akbar's revenue methods and assess their fiscal reach and limits.

Directive alignment: Compare methods by technique and suitability, then judge reach.

Introduction. Akbar's revenue administration was a repertoire rather than a single formula: its methods balanced information, local conditions and fiscal demand with uneven success.

Methods. **Zabti** used measured area and rates; when combined with the **dahsala** average of produce and prices, it supported cash assessment. **Batai/ghalla-bakhshi** divided crop in a fixed proportion, fitting circumstances where realised output mattered but requiring supervision and division. **Kankut** combined field measurement with inspection/appraisal of standing crop, while **nasaq** substantially relied on prior payment/assessment and estimate, avoiding a full fresh survey. Polaj, parati/parauti, chachar and banjar helped classify cultivation/fallow history; they should not be confused with a simple fertility scale.

Fiscal reach. Measurement, jarib standardisation, local dastur and provincial/central diwan records increased the state's ability to formulate a predictable claim. Cash demand connected assessment to coin and markets, and the system is associated with Lahore-to- Allahabad, Malwa and Gujarat. It financed court, campaign, service and household and checked officials through documentation.

Limits. A paper **jama** could differ from realised **hasil**. Zabt was not universal: difficult tracts, regional price/productivity variation and administrative capacity kept alternatives alive. Zamindars and village intermediaries mediated local reach; cesses, price risks, transport and coercive collection complicate welfare claims. Remission did not erase extraction.

Conclusion. The multiplicity of methods is not evidence of failure; it is evidence of pragmatic adaptation. It also marks the boundary of a state whose record capacity remained uneven.

Why this earns marks: It compares all four methods accurately, uses land categories and jama/hasil, and converts variation into an analytical judgment rather than a fact list.

Mains 8. [15 marks | 200 words] Assess the place of zamindars and local intermediaries in Akbar's revenue administration.

Directive alignment: Assess agency and constraint; avoid both disappearance and autonomy myths.

Introduction. Akbar's fiscal system increased official measurement and record-making, but it worked through rather than around local intermediaries.

Roles. At village and pargana levels, muqaddams/patels, patwaris, chaudhurs, qanungos, amils, treasurers and clerks supplied local knowledge, custody and records. Zamindars were local landed claimants and mediators in collection, with social authority and at times armed following. Their location between cultivator and state made them indispensable for information, mobilisation and negotiation.

Official framework. Zabti measurement, jarib, dastur and the provincial diwan sought to make the claim more legible to the centre. The chain—cultivator/local intermediary → amil and records → provincial diwan → central diwan—shows a layered rather than direct relationship. The difference between jama and hasil also reveals why nominal official demand depended on practical realisation.

Qualification. A zamindar was not simply a British landlord projected backward, nor the same as a transferable jagirdar. Nor should customary autonomy be romanticised: state demand, coercion and officials mattered. In some contexts local bargaining could constrain implementation; in others official pressure was acute.

Conclusion. Local intermediaries were a constitutive part of Mughal state capacity and a limit upon its uniformity, not a residue outside the state.

Why this earns marks: It locates actors in a revenue chain, distinguishes zamindar from jagirdar, and presents intermediary power as both resource and limit.

Mains 9. [20 marks | 250 words] Trace continuity and change from Sultanate and Sur practices to Akbar's administration.

Directive alignment: Trace a process across periods while avoiding “first invention” and mechanical-copy claims.

Introduction. Akbar's state was an exercise in selective inheritance: Sultanate and Sur techniques supplied administrative repertoires, while imperial expansion required greater specialisation, ranking and fiscal coordination.

Continuities. The Sultanate had revenue assignment through iqta and military/fiscal controls; the Sur regime is associated with measurement, roads, coins and administrative experimentation. Dagh and chehra offer the clearest continuity line: **Alauddin Khalji** introduced/used horse branding and descriptive rolls; **Sher Shah** revived/adapted them; **Akbar** systematised/reintroduced them in a Mughal framework. This evidence defeats an Akbar-first claim.

Changes under Akbar. The post-Bairam reduction of wakil power, stronger diwan specialisation and mir bakhshi's mansab/muster role created a more articulated central arrangement. In 1580, twelve subas replicated differentiated offices and central appointment. Mansabdari made status, remuneration and service part of one graded hierarchy and integrated Turani, Irani, Indian Muslim, Rajput, Afghan and other elites. Revenue experiments developed into measurement-based zabti and dahsala's ten-year produce-price averaging, associated with Muzaffar Khan, Todar Mal and Shah Mansur.

Qualification. Iqta and jagir were both revenue assignments linked to service but not interchangeable: compare tenure, audit, scale and their relation to rank. Akbar's system did not erase local intermediaries or make assessment universal. Batai, kankut and nasaq stayed necessary.

Conclusion. Continuity supplied techniques; Akbar's distinctive achievement was their coordinated use in ruler-centred systems of office, information, rank and fiscal calculation.

Why this earns marks: It traces rather than lists, gives the exact dagh/chehra provenance, compares iqta/jagir cautiously and explains what systematisation changed.

Mains 10. [20 marks | 250 words] How should Ain-i-Akbari be used to evaluate Akbar's state capacity? Give a balanced verdict.

Directive alignment: Evaluate a source as evidence and use it to reach—not assume—a verdict on state capacity.

Introduction. The *Ain-i-Akbari*, part of Abu'l Fazl's Akbarnama project, is indispensable for administrative vocabulary, norms and compiled data, but it is an imperial compendium and cannot be read as a modern census or a transparent record of universal practice.

What it reveals. Its categories illuminate the state imagined and claimed by Akbar's court: mansab rank, office, suba organisation, revenue terminology, household resources and fiscal order. Read alongside details such as the diwan's accounts, mir bakhshi's personnel records, dahsala calculation and provincial differentiation, it supports an argument for considerable early modern state capacity: rulers sought legible fields, ranked service, inspected horses and collected reports.

Source criticism. Abu'l Fazl wrote within a patronage relationship and presented an ideal imperial order; precision of figures does not by itself prove implementation in every village. Norm must be distinguished from practice, and administrative efficiency from justice. **Badauni** can reveal hostile/sectarian courtly reaction when relevant, but his

opposition is not a neutral social survey. Farmans, surviving revenue records, coins, inscriptions and later historians can corroborate particular orders, transactions, circulation or local variation, each with survival and genre limits.

Balanced state-capacity verdict. Akbar's system linked records, specialised offices, mansab, inspection, provincial replication and fiscal calculation more systematically than a loose personal retinue. Yet reach was uneven: alternatives to zabt, local zamindars, jama-hasil gaps, inspection evasion and coercive collection demonstrate limits. Capacity was real precisely because the court tried to manage these problems, not because its normative text made them disappear.

Conclusion. Use the Ain as a rich map of imperial administrative aspiration and repertoire, triangulated against other evidence; then a qualified, not triumphalist, account of Mughal state capacity follows.

Why this earns marks: It makes source criticism operational, names complementary evidence, and turns “capacity” into mechanisms and limitations rather than praise of figures.

Rapid recall grid

1580: 12 subas + dahsala

1573-74: dagh

1595-96: zat/sawar

jagir != ownership

dahsala != ten-year settlement

A final trigger list for high-frequency eliminations.

VISUAL 59

A final trigger list for high-frequency eliminations.

FINAL CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES — State & Government under Akbar

1. Chronology that prevents static answers

- **1556:** accession; Bairam Khan's powerful wakil-regency is the warning against an over-mighty coordinator.
- **1565:** diwan strengthens; fiscal work is a team and department story, not a single-hero story.
- **c. 1567:** numerical mansab hierarchy associated with the eleventh regnal year.
- **1573-74 (18th regnal year):** Akbar's Mughal-frame dagh measure; not first invention of dagh/chehra.
- **1580:** twelve subas and dahsala implementation; do not make either a finished all-India blueprint.
- **1595-96 (40th regnal year):** explicit zat-sawar distinction; do not project it unchanged backward.

2. State form: centralised, personal, differentiated

- Emperor: appointment, justice, revenue, military command and patronage remain concentrated at the centre.
- Wakil: Bairam Khan lesson -> prestige survives; effective monopoly is curbed.
- Diwan/diwan-i-ala: income-expenditure, accounts, khalisa-jagir-inam scrutiny; name **Muzaffar Khan Turbati + Todar Mal + Shah Mansur**.
- Mir bakhshi: mansab presentation/recommendation, muster/personnel record, associated news/intelligence; not a modern defence minister.
- Mir saman/khan-i-saman: household, stores and karkhanas = material state capacity.
- Sadr-us-sudur/qazi-ul-quzat: grants and judicial-religious functions; no modern autonomous welfare/judicial analogy.
- Formula: **office differentiation + central appointment + cross-reporting -> ruler-centred check**, not separation of powers.

3. Administrative ladder and local mediation

- **Suba -> sarkar -> pargana -> village**; ascending territorial size = **pargana -> sarkar -> suba**.
- 1580: twelve subas; provincial subadar, diwan, bakhshi, sadr-qazi and reporting apparatus balance one another.
- Sarkar: distinguish faujdar's coercive/order field from amil-guzar/amalguzar revenue work; jurisdiction may vary.
- Pargana: shiqdar, amil, qanungo, potdar and karkun form a record/collection cluster.
- Village: muqaddam/patel, patwari, chaudhuri, zamindar and custom; neither direct-uniform state reach nor romantic autonomy.
- Khalisa = crown revenue; jagir = assigned state revenue; madad-i-maash/inam = grant. **Jagir != ownership**.
- Jagirdar = generally transferable assignee; zamindar = local claimant/intermediary with social/armed resource.

4. Mansabdari: remember the triad

- **Mansab = rank + remuneration + service obligation**, a single civil-military imperial service.
- Ranks begin at 10; high 5000 and exceptional 7000 under Akbar; no single rigid all-reign table.
- Composite elite: Turani, Irani, Indian Muslim, Rajput, Afghan and others; integration does not equal equality.
- **Zat = personal rank/status/pay; sawar = cavalry obligation**, explicit in 1595-96.
- Cash and jagir payment coexist; jama/dami valuation is not equivalent to realised hasil.
- Transfer, promotion, demotion and assignment create dependence; elite family advantage and hierarchy persist.
- **Not hereditary feudal title; not modern merit civil service.**

5. Dagh, chehra, army and information

- Provenance mnemonic: **Alauddin used -> Sher Shah renewed -> Akbar systematised**.
- Dagh = brand horse; chehra = describe soldier; goal = reduce fictitious muster/substitution.
- Limit: resistance, harassment, inspection cost and paper-versus-actual troop gap.
- Army: mansabdar contingents + ahadis + artillery/infantry/elephants where relevant; cavalry central; not modern standing army.
- News writers and records improve oversight, but no claim of one uniform modern intelligence agency.

6. Revenue logic and terminology

- Objective: predictable fiscal claim, military/court/household finance, knowledge of cultivation, control of officials/intermediaries; **not welfare-only**.
- Sher Shah precedent -> Akbar experiments -> local circles/records -> 1580 dahsala.
- **Zabti = measurement-based assessment. Dahsala = ten-year produce-price averaging.**
- Dahsala: theoretical one-third of average produce in cash; **not a permanent ten-year settlement**.
- Jarib with bamboo/iron rings = standardising measurement evidence; do not assign universal modern bigha equivalence.
- Polaj/parati(ch)/chachar/banjar = cultivation/fallow history, not fertility-only ladder.
- Batai = crop share; kankut = measurement + standing crop estimate; nasaq = previous-demand estimate.
- Safe reach: Lahore to Allahabad, Malwa, Gujarat. Alternatives prove zabt was not universal.
- Jama = assessed demand; hasil = realised receipt. Cash nexus is uneven, not complete commercialisation.
- Remission/taccavi may support cultivation; cesses, transport, price risk and coercion qualify benevolence.

7. Comparisons and limits

- Iqta vs jagir: both revenue-service assignments; compare tenure, audit, scale and rank relation—avoid identity/invention claims.
- Sher Shah vs Akbar: continuity plus refinement; not mere copying, not Akbar-first.
- Capacity = rank + record + inspection + revenue + provincial replication + household supply + news.
- Limits = local intermediaries, uneven reach, corruption, nominal contingents, cash-price risk, coercion, jama-hasil gaps, transfer incentive.
- Later jagirdari crisis belongs chiefly to Topics 21/25; here identify only structural seeds.

8. Source discipline and PYQ route

- Ain-i-Akbari: administrative compendium/data/ideal order in Akbarnama project; useful for categories/norms, not census-like proof of universal practice.
- Abu'l Fazl: imperial ideology/praise; Badauni: hostile/sectarian lens; triangulate with farmans, records, coins, inscriptions and historians.
- 2021 Prelims GS-I Q45 direct/owned: exact local-paper wording and option order reproduced above; **(a) inferred, high confidence, not officially verified**.
- 2019 jagirdar-zamindar is Topic 24 adjacent; 2025 religious syncretism is Topic 17 adjacent.

9. Twenty-second recall

1. 1580 = twelve subas + dahsala.
2. 1573-74 = Akbar's dagh; 1595-96 = zat-sawar.
3. Pargana -> sarkar -> suba.
4. Jagir is revenue assignment, not land title.
5. Zabti measures; dahsala averages.
6. One-third is theoretical claim; realised burden can differ.
7. Team, not Todar Mal alone.
8. Ruler-centred checks, not constitutional separation.
9. Ain gives norms/ideal order; test practice.
10. Best verdict: systematised but uneven early modern imperial capacity.

10. Last-minute answer compression

- For an **administration** question, use: Bairam-wakil correction -> diwan/mir bakhshi functions -> twelve subas -> ruler-centred qualification.
- For a **mansabdari** question, use: rank-salary-service -> composite elite -> 1595-96 zat/sawar -> dagh/chehra -> jagir-transfer tension.
- For a **revenue** question, use: Sur precedent/team -> zabti versus dahsala -> jarib/rates -> alternatives -> jama-hasil/local mediation.
- For a **sources** question, use: Ain category/norm -> Abu'l Fazl patronage -> Badauni's situated dissent -> corroborating traces -> norm-practice verdict.
- Never write "Akbar invented dagh/chehra," "dahsala was a permanent ten-year settlement," "jagir was land ownership," "zabt was universal," or "subas were federal provinces."
- Named evidence should perform a job: 1580 dates reorganisation; 1595-96 dates refinement; jarib shows measurement; jama-hasil shows fiscal gap; a zamindar shows mediated reach.

11. Three one-line verdicts

- **State:** "Centralisation was a ruler-centred increase in reportability, not the creation of impersonal constitutional administration."
- **Mansab:** "The mansab joined honour, remuneration and military obligation, making elite integration an instrument of command."
- **Dahsala:** "The ten-year average made a fiscal claim more legible, while alternative methods and local risk marked the boundary of uniform implementation."

12. Final caution

- State capacity is not a synonym for a modern state. In this topic it means the court's enlarged ability to classify, rank, record, inspect, assign and collect through people whose cooperation and local knowledge it could never fully replace.